VOLUME 4

ELIJAH MUST FIRST COME



MALACHI'S PROMISE, JOHN'S ANSWER, AND THE COMING THE LORD STILL NAMES

THE PROPHETS SERIES

Table of Contents

Preface....2
Thesis....3
1. Malachi's Close: The Law, Horeb and the Curse....4
2. Elijah in Kings: The Man the Promise Names....6
3. The Whirlwind and What Came After....10
4. The Messenger Before the Lord: Malachi 3:1....13
5. The Voice in the Wilderness: Isaiah 40....15
6. Gabriel's Word: Luke 1....17
7. John's Answer: "I Am Not"....20
8. The Lord's Answer About John....22
9. The Mountain and the Question: Matthew 17 and Mark 9....25
10. Who Do Men Say? The Crowds, Herod and the Cross....27
11. "Shall First Come" and "Is Come Already"....30
12. Objections and Replies....33
Conclusion....36
Appendix A. The Passages at a Glance....38
Appendix B. Key Words....39
Appendix C. Questions for Study....40
Appendix D. The Key Passages in Full....41
Appendix E. Where the Passages Are Read....46
Bibliography....54

Preface

This volume argues a position. It does not gather what churches say about Elijah and leave the reader to choose. It says what the author believes the Scriptures teach about the prophet who was promised before the day of the LORD, it gives the evidence from the verses in the order the verses stand, and it answers the strongest objections in the objectors' own words, so that a reader who disagrees knows exactly where.

The question is narrow, and the prophet who closes the Old Testament raises it. The last words of Malachi are a promise and a warning: "Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD: and he shall turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers, lest I come and smite the earth with a curse" (Malachi 4:5, 6). The Old Testament ends on that verse, and when the Gospels begin, the promise is on everyone's lips. Priests and Levites ask John, "Art thou Elias?" (John 1:21). The disciples ask the Lord, "Why then say the scribes that Elias must first come?" (Matthew 17:10). The crowd at Caesarea Philippi says that some think Jesus himself is Elias (Matthew 16:14). At the cross, someone hears the cry and says, "Let be, let us see whether Elias will come to save him" (Matthew 27:49).

Readers have answered the question in three ways. Some say the promise was kept in John the Baptist and is finished. Some say it was not kept at all, and that John had nothing to do with it. Some say it was kept in part and still waits. Each reading can quote a verse. The first quotes "Elias is come already" (Matthew 17:12), the second quotes John's "I am not" (John 1:21), and the third quotes "Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things" (Matthew 17:11). This volume holds that all three verses stand, that they were spoken by different persons to different hearers for different ends, and that none of them is allowed to cancel the others.

The position is this. Malachi promises one Elijah the prophet, sent by the LORD, before the great and dreadful day. The Gospels answer in three voices. Gabriel tells Zacharias that his son will go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elias" (Luke 1:17). John, asked to his face whether he is Elias, says, "I am not" (John 1:21). The Lord says of John, "And if ye will receive it, this is Elias, which was for to come" (Matthew 11:14), and then, after John is dead, says both that "Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things" and that "Elias is come already, and they knew him not" (Matthew 17:11, 12). The volume reads the three voices together as an offer made to Israel in John's day and conditional on its reception. The offer was refused, the restoring of all things is not reported done, the day of the LORD has not come, and the text therefore points to a further coming of Elijah before that day.

Three things about the method. First, the volume reads the King James Version only, and every Scripture quotation is checked word for word against it. Second, each chapter opens with a claim, reads its passages in order, and closes with a short table and a list of what the volume takes from the passages, so that the reader can see what has been argued and test it. Third, where modern writers are named, they are named for a position the author has read in a free text, and where an objection is stated, it is stated as the objector would state it and then answered from the verses.

The volume does not take up what its neighbours argue. Prophetic Commentary Volume 2 sets Malachi 4:5, 6 and Matthew 17:10, 11 beside the false prophet of Revelation 13 as the counterfeit of Elijah; this volume does not re-argue that counterfeit and asks only who the genuine prophet is. The two witnesses of Revelation 11 are read in the places that read them; this volume sets the chapter beside Malachi, lists what the text of Revelation 11 itself says, and does not put a name on the witnesses. The Lord's ministry to Israel is the subject of Gospel Commentary Volume 2, the apostles' question in Acts 1:6 and the times of restitution in Acts 3:21 of Acts Commentary Volume 1, and the day of the LORD of Study 7. The volume cites these and does not repeat them. It also leaves aside what it cannot settle from the text: the date of the day, the place and the hour of Elijah's coming, and the question of what he will say.

One boundary runs through the whole volume. Every passage here is addressed to Israel. Malachi speaks to Israel by the hand of a prophet (Malachi 1:1), Gabriel to a priest of Israel in the temple, John to the people at the Jordan, and the Lord to his disciples about Israel's expectation. The Body of Christ is not named in any of these passages and is not read into them. The volume draws nothing from them for the Body's calling, hope or conduct.

Thesis

Malachi promises one Elijah the prophet before the day of the LORD. John came in the spirit and power of Elias and was offered to Israel as the Elias who was to come; Israel did not receive him, and the Lord, speaking after John's death, still says that Elias shall first come and restore all things.

The thesis in four statements.

Statement	What it says	Where it is argued
1	The promise is of one man, Elijah the prophet, sent by the LORD before the great and dreadful day. The messenger of Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3 is a second promise, and the Gospels join the two on John.	Chapters 1, 4 and 5
2	Gabriel, John and the Lord each speak of John's relation to Elijah in different words, and each statement stands as written: in the spirit and power of Elias; "I am not"; "if ye will receive it, this is Elias."	Chapters 6, 7 and 8
3	The Lord's answer on the mountain has two parts that the volume does not let cancel each other: "Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things," and "Elias is come already, and they knew him not." John is dead when the first is spoken.	Chapters 9 and 11

Statement	What it says	Where it is argued
4	The restoring of all things is not reported done, the day of the LORD has not come, and the text therefore holds a further coming of Elijah before that day, in Israel's line; the Body of Christ is not in these passages.	Chapters 10 and 11

A reader may test the thesis in one move. Put the three statements of John's relation to Elijah side by side, and ask whether the text lets any one of them be dropped. If Gabriel's sentence is dropped, John's "I am not" and the Lord's "this is Elias" stand against each other with nothing to join them. If John's denial is dropped, the Lord's words are heard as simple identity and the question of the priests and Levites is left without an answer. If the Lord's second sentence on the mountain is dropped, he said only that Elias had come, and Matthew 17:11 has nothing to say. If the first is dropped, the Lord's own "truly shall first come" has nothing to mean. The thesis stands if the four stand together; the volume argues that they do.

1. Malachi's Close: The Law, Horeb and the Curse

Claim: the promise of Elijah is the last paragraph of the Old Testament, and it cannot be read apart from the paragraph around it. Malachi 4:4–6 joins three things: a command to remember the law of Moses given at Horeb, a promise to send Elijah the prophet, and a warning of a curse. The prophet who is promised is promised to Israel, before a day, and for a work done on hearts. The volume reads the three verses in order and asks what each says and what each leaves unsaid.

1.1 The book and its audience

The book opens, "The burden of the word of the LORD to Israel by Malachi" (Malachi 1:1). The audience is named in the first verse and is never changed. The book that follows is a series of disputes between the LORD and Israel in which the people ask, "Wherein hast thou loved us?" (Malachi 1:2), "Wherein have we despised thy name?" (Malachi 1:6) and "Wherein have we wearied him?" (Malachi 2:17). The priests are charged with offering polluted bread, the people with unfaithfulness to the wife of their youth, and all with robbing God in tithes and offerings (Malachi 1:6–8; 2:14–16; 3:8). The book is the LORD's indictment of his people and a promise to them at the same time. The second volume of this series reads the charges against the priests and the offerings; this chapter needs only the point that the audience of the last paragraph is the audience of the first.

1.2 The day that burns

The last paragraph begins in the verses before it. Malachi 3:1–5 announced a messenger, the sudden coming of the LORD to his temple, and a judgment on sorcerers, adulterers and false swearers. Malachi 3:13–18 records the faithful speaking to one another, a book of remembrance, and the promise, "And they shall be mine, saith the LORD of hosts, in that day when I make up my jewels" (Malachi 3:17). Then chapter 4 opens with the day itself: "For, behold, the day cometh, that shall burn as an oven; and all the proud, yea, and all that do wickedly, shall be stubble: and the

day that cometh shall burn them up, saith the LORD of hosts, that it shall leave them neither root nor branch" (Malachi 4:1).

Two outcomes are set side by side. The proud and the wicked are stubble. "But unto you that fear my name shall the Sun of righteousness arise with healing in his wings; and ye shall go forth, and grow up as calves of the stall" (Malachi 4:2). The speaker turns from the day in the third person to a "you" who fear his name, and the "you" is Israel in the book's own address. "And ye shall tread down the wicked; for they shall be ashes under the soles of your feet in the day that I shall do this, saith the LORD of hosts" (Malachi 4:3). The day is a day of fire and a day of healing, and the same day does both. It is the day the next three verses are about.

1.3 Remember the law of Moses

Between the day and the prophet stands a command: "Remember ye the law of Moses my servant, which I commanded unto him in Horeb for all Israel, with the statutes and judgments" (Malachi 4:4). The sentence is easily passed over, and it should not be. It names the law as Moses' and as the LORD's, it names Horeb as the place it was given, and it names "all Israel" as the people it was given to. Malachi is the last of the prophets in the English Old Testament, and his last act is to point back to the first foundation of Israel's life with God. The book ends looking at Sinai and looking forward to a day.

The order of the three verses matters. The command to remember the law is not a charge against a particular sin. It is a call to the whole people to hold what was given. It stands before the promise of the prophet, and nothing in the paragraph says why the command stands there. The volume notes the placement and builds nothing on it, except one thing: the promise that follows is a promise in Israel's line, to a people with a law, a land and a temple, and not a promise addressed to anyone outside that line.

1.4 Elijah the prophet

"Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD" (Malachi 4:5). Eight things can be read out of the verse without adding anything. The speaker is the LORD: "I will send." The sending is future. It is addressed to a plural "you," the same Israel of the book. The one sent is named, "Elijah," and given a title, "the prophet." The title is the one the book of Kings gives him when he comes near the altar on Carmel: "Elijah the prophet came near, and said, LORD God of Abraham, Isaac, and of Israel" (1 Kings 18:36). The sending is set before an event, "the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD." The day is called great and dreadful, and the verse does not say what happens in it. And the verse says nothing of his baptizing, preaching in a wilderness or announcing a person. Those come from other texts.

The volume draws one conclusion at this point and no more. The verse names a man. A reader may say that the name is a title for an office or a type, and that is the position of some writers who are answered in the last chapter. The verse as written says "Elijah the prophet," and the same name and title are used in the narrative of Kings of a man who lived and spoke. Nothing in the verse itself marks the name as figurative. The volume therefore reads the promise as a promise of Elijah, and tests that reading against every passage that follows.

1.5 What the prophet does, and the curse

"And he shall turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers, lest I come and smite the earth with a curse" (Malachi 4:6). The work is a work on hearts. The "fathers" and the "children" are not further identified by Malachi, and the volume does not guess. The purpose clause, "lest I come and smite the earth with a curse," gives the work its reason. If the hearts are not turned, the LORD comes and smites. The last word of the Old Testament in the English Bible is "curse," and the word is the sign of the Mosaic covenant's own sanctions: Deuteronomy 28 sets blessings and curses before Israel (Deuteronomy 28:15). The promise of Elijah is a promise of a work meant to avert the curse.

Two things follow, and the later chapters will test them. The first is that the work is conditional in its end. The prophet turns hearts so that the LORD does not have to smite, and the verse states no guarantee that all the hearts are turned. The second is that the work comes before the day and is aimed at it. The day is not the prophet's coming; the prophet's coming is a mercy before the day.

Malachi 4:4–6 in four questions.

Question	The text	Passage
Who speaks?	The LORD of hosts, to Israel by Malachi	Malachi 1:1; 4:3
Who is sent?	Elijah the prophet, by name and by title	Malachi 4:5; 1 Kings 18:36
When?	Before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD	Malachi 4:5
To do what?	To turn the heart of the fathers to the children and the children to their fathers, lest the LORD come and smite the earth with a curse	Malachi 4:6

1.6 What the volume takes from the passage

- Malachi is addressed to Israel from its first verse to its last, and the promise of Elijah is a promise to that people.
- The command to remember the law of Moses given at Horeb stands between the day and the prophet, and the promise belongs to Israel's line.
- Malachi 4:5 names a man, Elijah the prophet, and gives him the title the book of Kings gives him; nothing in the verse marks the name as a figure.
- The prophet's work is on hearts and has a purpose, that the LORD not come and smite the earth with a curse.
- The promise is a promise of a mercy before the day, and the day is not the prophet's coming.

2. Elijah in Kings: The Man the Promise Names

Claim: if Malachi 4:5 names a man, the first thing to ask is who the man was and what he did, and the book of Kings answers in five scenes. Each scene is read here as written, and each is tied to the later text that takes it up, so that a reader can see

which of Elijah's works the New Testament recalls and which it does not. The scenes also contain two links to Malachi's own paragraph that are easy to miss: Elijah's prayer on Carmel uses the very phrase of Malachi 4:6, and his one great journey ends at the mountain named in Malachi 4:4.

2.1 The shut heaven

Elijah enters the record without introduction. "And Elijah the Tishbite, who was of the inhabitants of Gilead, said unto Ahab, As the LORD God of Israel liveth, before whom I stand, there shall not be dew nor rain these years, but according to my word" (1 Kings 17:1). He is named, he is given a place, he stands "before" the LORD, and he sets a term on the heaven: no dew or rain "but according to my word." The word is his only because it is first the LORD's, for the next verse says, "And the word of the LORD came unto him, saying" (1 Kings 17:2), and the brook, the ravens and the widow of Zarephath follow at the LORD's command (1 Kings 17:3, 4, 9).

Three later texts take up the shut heaven, and each gives a number or a name. The Lord says in the synagogue at Nazareth that there were many widows in Israel "in the days of Elias, when the heaven was shut up three years and six months, when great famine was throughout all the land" (Luke 4:25). James writes that Elias "prayed earnestly that it might not rain: and it rained not on the earth by the space of three years and six months" (James 5:17). The book of Kings itself says only that the word came to Elijah "in the third year" (1 Kings 18:1). James adds that "Elias was a man subject to like passions as we are" (James 5:17), which is the New Testament's own statement that the man was a man. Gospel Commentary Volume 2 reads the Nazareth sermon as the Lord's account of Israel's history, and this volume cites it and does not repeat it. Revelation 11:6 speaks of "power to shut heaven, that it rain not in the days of their prophecy," and the verse is cited here and read in chapter 11, where the figures of the witnesses are set out and not named.

2.2 The widow's son

At Zarephath the widow's son falls sick "and his sickness was so sore, that there was no breath left in him" (1 Kings 17:17). The woman's first thought is of her sin, and Elijah's is of the LORD's name: "O LORD my God, hast thou also brought evil upon the widow with whom I sojourn, by slaying her son?" (1 Kings 17:20). He stretches himself on the child three times and prays, "let this child's soul come into him again," and "the LORD heard the voice of Elijah; and the soul of the child came into him again, and he revived" (1 Kings 17:21, 22). The woman's verdict is the verdict of the scene: "Now by this I know that thou art a man of God, and that the word of the LORD in thy mouth is truth" (1 Kings 17:24).

The scene is the first raising of the dead recorded in the Bible, and the volume names it for one reason only. The Lord's words at Nazareth about Elias say that he "was sent" to a widow of Sidon, "unto Sarepta, a city of Sidon" (Luke 4:26), the same Zarephath. The sending is the Lord's own word for the errand of 1 Kings 17:9, and it will matter later that the Lord uses the verb of sending for Elijah, as Malachi does.

2.3 Carmel: the heart turned back

The third year brings the meeting with Ahab. "Art thou he that troubleth Israel?" the king asks, and Elijah answers, "I have not troubled Israel; but thou, and thy father's house, in that ye have forsaken the commandments of the LORD, and thou hast followed Baalim" (1 Kings 18:17, 18). The contest is set on Carmel with "all Israel" and

four hundred and fifty prophets of Baal (1 Kings 18:19). Elijah's first word is to the people: "How long halt ye between two opinions? if the LORD be God, follow him: but if Baal, then follow him. And the people answered him not a word" (1 Kings 18:21). He says of himself, "I, even I only, remain a prophet of the LORD" (1 Kings 18:22).

Two details of the altar bear on Malachi. "And he repaired the altar of the LORD that was broken down. And Elijah took twelve stones, according to the number of the tribes of the sons of Jacob, unto whom the word of the LORD came, saying, Israel shall be thy name" (1 Kings 18:30, 31). The altar is Israel's altar and is rebuilt for all twelve tribes, in a day when the kingdom was divided. It is the work of one man at an altar for the whole people. And at the evening sacrifice he prays: "Hear me, O LORD, hear me, that this people may know that thou art the LORD God, and that thou hast turned their heart back again" (1 Kings 18:37). The fire falls, the people fall on their faces, and they say, "The LORD, he is the God; the LORD, he is the God" (1 Kings 18:38, 39).

The phrase in the prayer is "turned their heart back again." Malachi's is "turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers" (Malachi 4:6). The English words are the same word, to turn the heart, and the direction in Kings is toward the LORD, as Luke 1:16 says of John: "And many of the children of Israel shall he turn to the Lord their God." The volume does not say that Malachi 4:6 is only the Carmel work repeated. It says that the one scene in which the Bible shows Elijah turning a whole people's heart is a scene in which he uses Malachi's phrase, and that a reader who asks what the promised prophet's work will look like has the answer in Kings.

2.4 Horeb

After Carmel, Jezebel's threat sends Elijah south to Beer-sheba and into the wilderness, where he sits under a juniper tree and asks to die (1 Kings 19:2–4). An angel feeds him twice and he goes "in the strength of that meat forty days and forty nights unto Horeb the mount of God" (1 Kings 19:8). He lodges in a cave, and the LORD asks the question twice: "What doest thou here, Elijah?" (1 Kings 19:9, 13). The answer is the same both times: "I have been very jealous for the LORD God of hosts: because the children of Israel have forsaken thy covenant, thrown down thine altars, and slain thy prophets with the sword; and I, even I only, am left; and they seek my life, to take it away" (1 Kings 19:14).

Horeb is the mountain named in Malachi 4:4: "the law of Moses my servant, which I commanded unto him in Horeb for all Israel." Elijah is the one prophet whose recorded journey ends at that mountain, and he goes there to say that Israel has forsaken the covenant given there. The wind, the earthquake and the fire pass, and the LORD is not in them, "and after the fire a still small voice" (1 Kings 19:11, 12). Then the LORD commissions him: Hazael, Jehu and Elisha, and an answer to his loneliness: "Yet I have left me seven thousand in Israel, all the knees which have not bowed unto Baal, and every mouth which hath not kissed him" (1 Kings 19:15–18). Elijah's own report is that all Israel is against him; the LORD's is that a seven thousand remain. The volume notes the contrast and leaves the seven thousand to the places that read them.

Elisha's call comes in the same chapter: Elijah "passed by him, and cast his mantle upon him," and Elisha "arose, and went after Elijah, and ministered unto him" (1 Kings

19:19, 21). The mantle, which falls again in 2 Kings 2, is the first sign that the prophet's work can pass to another.

2.5 Naboth's vineyard

The last scene in 1 Kings is a word of judgment. Ahab has taken Naboth's vineyard, and the LORD sends Elijah: "Hast thou killed, and also taken possession?" (1 Kings 21:19). Ahab answers, "Hast thou found me, O mine enemy?" and the prophet says, "I have found thee: because thou hast sold thyself to work evil in the sight of the LORD" (1 Kings 21:20). The sentence on the house is set out. Then comes the moment that matters for the volume: "And it came to pass, when Ahab heard those words, that he rent his clothes, and put sackcloth upon his flesh, and fasted" (1 Kings 21:27). The LORD says to Elijah, "Seest thou how Ahab humbleth himself before me? because he humbleth himself before me, I will not bring the evil in his days: but in his son's days will I bring the evil upon his house" (1 Kings 21:29).

The scene shows what the first volume of this series reads as the conditional word of a prophet. A judgment spoken by Elijah is delayed when the man judged humbles himself. The volume draws one point from it for the question of Malachi's Elijah. The prophet who is to come before the day is a prophet whose word may be answered, and the LORD's answer to a turned heart is mercy for a time.

2.6 Ahaziah and the fire

The book of Kings closes its first volume with Ahaziah, who falls through a lattice and sends to Baal-zebub of Ekron. The angel of the LORD tells Elijah to meet the messengers: "Is it not because there is not a God in Israel, that ye go to enquire of Baal-zebub the god of Ekron?" (2 Kings 1:3). The king asks what manner of man met them, and they answer, "He was an hairy man, and girt with a girdle of leather about his loins. And he said, It is Elijah the Tishbite" (2 Kings 1:8). The text does not say whether the "hairy" is the man's or his garment's. Mark's description of John is that he "was clothed with camel's hair, and with a girdle of a skin about his loins" (Mark 1:6), and the likeness is in the wording and is noted without being pressed.

Fire falls twice on captains of fifty, "If I be a man of God, then let fire come down from heaven, and consume thee and thy fifty" (2 Kings 1:10, 12), and the third captain falls on his knees and begs, "let my life now be precious in thy sight," and the angel says, "Go down with him: be not afraid of him" (2 Kings 1:13, 15). The disciples will recall the fire when a Samaritan village refuses the Lord, and their words, "wilt thou that we command fire to come down from heaven, and consume them, even as Elias did?" (Luke 9:54), are the New Testament's only direct reference to this scene. The Lord's answer is read in chapter 10.

Elijah's works in Kings and the later texts that take them up.

Scene	What the text says	Later text
The shut heaven (1 Kings 17:1; 18:1)	No dew or rain but at his word; the third year	Luke 4:25; James 5:17, 18; Revelation 11:6 (cited)
The widow of Zarephath (1 Kings 17:8–24)	Sent to a widow of Sidon; her son revived	Luke 4:26
Carmel (1 Kings 18)	Twelve stones; fire; "turned their heart back again"	Malachi 4:6; Luke 1:16
Horeb (1 Kings 19)	Forty days to the mount of God; "I, even I only, am left"; the seven thousand	Malachi 4:4
Naboth (1 Kings 21)	A judgment delayed when the king humbles himself	The conditional word
Ahaziah (2 Kings 1)	A hairy man; fire from heaven on captains of fifty	Mark 1:6; Luke 9:54

2.7 What the volume takes from the passages

- Kings gives Elijah a name, a place, a title and a life, and the New Testament speaks of him as a man subject to like passions as we are.
- On Carmel he prays that the people may know the LORD "hast turned their heart back again," which is the work Malachi 4:6 names.
- Elijah's one long journey ends at Horeb, the mountain named in Malachi 4:4.
- A word of judgment spoken by Elijah was delayed when Ahab humbled himself, and the prophet's work is shown as aimed at turning.
- The fire of 2 Kings 1 is the one act of Elijah the disciples name in the Gospels as an example to follow, and the Lord answers them; the answer is read in chapter 10.

3. The Whirlwind and What Came After

Claim: Elijah's departure is the second fact the promise rests on. He did not die. He "went up by a whirlwind into heaven" (2 Kings 2:11), and the text of Kings shows at once that the prophets of the day treated the matter as open and that his spirit was seen on another man. Both facts bear on Malachi 4:5. The first says that the man named in the promise has not been reported dead. The second says that a man may bear Elijah's spirit and not be Elijah, which is the point on which the Gospels' account of John turns. A writing from Elijah is also recorded in Chronicles, and the volume reports the passage and builds nothing on its timing.

3.1 The last journey

The chapter opens with its own announcement: "when the LORD would take up Elijah into heaven by a whirlwind, that Elijah went with Elisha from Gilgal" (2 Kings 2:1).

Three times Elijah tells Elisha to tarry, because the LORD has sent him to Beth-el, to Jericho and to Jordan, and three times Elisha answers, "As the LORD liveth, and as thy soul liveth, I will not leave thee" (2 Kings 2:2, 4, 6). At Beth-el and at Jericho the sons of the prophets say the same thing to Elisha: "Knowest thou that the LORD will take away thy master from thy head to day?" (2 Kings 2:3, 5). The event is known beforehand to the prophets' company, and Elisha's answer, "Yea, I know it; hold ye your peace," shows that he knows it too.

At Jordan fifty men stand "to view afar off," and Elijah "took his mantle, and wrapped it together, and smote the waters, and they were divided hither and thither, so that they two went over on dry ground" (2 Kings 2:7, 8). The mantle that was cast on Elisha in 1 Kings 19:19 is the instrument here. The crossing is of the river Israel crossed under Joshua, on dry ground, and the text does not draw the parallel; the volume notes the geography and no more.

3.2 A double portion

On the farther bank Elijah says, "Ask what I shall do for thee, before I be taken away from thee," and Elisha asks, "let a double portion of thy spirit be upon me" (2 Kings 2:9). The answer is carefully worded. "Thou hast asked a hard thing: nevertheless, if thou see me when I am taken from thee, it shall be so unto thee; but if not, it shall not be so" (2 Kings 2:10). The gift is not Elijah's to give, and the sign that it is granted is that Elisha sees the departure.

Then the event itself: "there appeared a chariot of fire, and horses of fire, and parted them both asunder; and Elijah went up by a whirlwind into heaven" (2 Kings 2:11). Elisha cries, "My father, my father, the chariot of Israel, and the horsemen thereof. And he saw him no more" (2 Kings 2:12). The words "he saw him no more" are the narrator's report of what Elisha saw, and the next verses show what the prophets' company concluded.

3.3 The spirit of Elijah rests on Elisha

Elisha takes up the mantle that fell, returns to Jordan and asks, "Where is the LORD God of Elijah?" (2 Kings 2:13, 14). The waters part for him, and the sons of the prophets at Jericho, who had watched from the other side, say, "The spirit of Elijah doth rest on Elisha" (2 Kings 2:15). They bow to the ground before him. A man other than Elijah is recognized as bearing Elijah's spirit, and the recognition is made by the prophets themselves. He is not called Elijah, and the narrator does not call him Elijah. He is Elisha, the son of Shaphat, "which poured water on the hands of Elijah" (2 Kings 3:11), and Jehoshaphat says of him, "The word of the LORD is with him" (2 Kings 3:12).

This is the precedent the volume wants. The Old Testament itself shows that the spirit of Elijah can rest on a man who is not Elijah, that the prophets can say so in those words, and that the man is received in that character. When Gabriel says that a son of Zacharias will go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elias" (Luke 1:17), the form of the sentence is the form of 2 Kings 2:15. The sentence does not say that the man will be Elijah, and the volume reads it so in chapter 6.

3.4 The search of three days

The sons of the prophets are not content. "Behold now, there be with thy servants fifty strong men; let them go, we pray thee, and seek thy master: lest peradventure the

Spirit of the LORD hath taken him up, and cast him upon some mountain, or into some valley" (2 Kings 2:16). Elisha forbids it, then yields when they urge him "till he was ashamed," and they "sought three days, but found him not" (2 Kings 2:17). When they return, he says only, "Did I not say unto you, Go not?" (2 Kings 2:18).

The passage gives the company's fear and the failure of the search, and it gives nothing further. It does not say where Elijah is. It says he went up "into heaven," and it says that three days of searching by fifty men found no body. The volume draws from this a narrow point. Kings reports Elijah's going and does not report his death, and no passage of the Old Testament says he died. Hebrews 11:5 says the same of Enoch, "was not found, because God had translated him," and the volume cites that line only to note that Scripture records two men removed without death and does not explain how.

3.5 The writing to Jehoram

One more text in the Old Testament names Elijah after the whirlwind, and it is a hard one. In the days of Jehoram of Judah, "there came a writing to him from Elijah the prophet, saying, Thus saith the LORD God of David thy father, Because thou hast not walked in the ways of Jehoshaphat thy father, nor in the ways of Asa king of Judah, but hast walked in the way of the kings of Israel, and hast made Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem to go a whoring, like to the whoredoms of the house of Ahab, and also hast slain thy brethren of thy father's house, which were better than thyself: behold, with a great plague will the LORD smite thy people, and thy children, and thy wives, and all thy goods: and thou shalt have great sickness by disease of thy bowels" (2 Chronicles 21:12–15).

The passage gives a writing from "Elijah the prophet" and gives no date for the writing in relation to the whirlwind. The chronological notices that join the reigns of Judah and Israel in Kings and Chronicles are a known difficulty, and readers differ on whether the writing was sent before the whirlwind or after it. The volume builds nothing on the point. It reports that the writing is in the record, that it comes in the name of "the LORD God of David thy father," and that its subject is Judah's king and not Israel's. The prophet's word reaches the house of David, and it is a word of judgment on a king who followed Ahab's house.

Elijah after the Kings account, as the passages state it.

Passage	What is stated	What is not stated
2 Kings 2:1, 11	Taken up by a whirlwind into heaven; a chariot and horses of fire	That he died; where he is
2 Kings 2:9, 10	A double portion of his spirit asked; granted if Elisha sees him go	That the gift is Elijah's to give
2 Kings 2:15	"The spirit of Elijah doth rest on Elisha"	That Elisha is called Elijah
2 Kings 2:16–18	Fifty men search three days and find nothing	Any report of his body

Passage	What is stated	What is not stated
2 Kings 3:11, 12	Elisha, who poured water on Elijah's hands; "The word of the LORD is with him"	Any further word of Elijah in that chapter
2 Chronicles 21:12–15	A writing from Elijah the prophet to Jehoram of Judah	When the writing was sent

3.6 What the volume takes from the passages

- Elijah was taken up by a whirlwind into heaven, and the Old Testament reports no death.
- The sons of the prophets treated his going as open: a search of three days, and no report of a body.
- The prophets said of Elisha, "The spirit of Elijah doth rest on Elisha," and he is received so without being called Elijah. A man may bear Elijah's spirit and not be Elijah.
- A writing from Elijah to Jehoram of Judah is in the record; the volume reports it and builds nothing on its timing.
- Malachi's promise, "I will send you Elijah the prophet," is made after all of this, and names the man with the title he bore in Kings.

4. The Messenger Before the Lord: Malachi 3:1

Claim: Malachi speaks of a forerunner twice, and the two sayings are not the same saying. In 3:1 the LORD says, "I will send my messenger," and the one who follows is the LORD himself, coming suddenly to his temple. In 4:5 the LORD says, "I will send you Elijah the prophet," and what follows is the great and dreadful day. The Gospels quote the first and leave the second where Malachi put it. A reader who keeps the two apart can see why the Gospels can say that John fulfils the one and still leave the other open.

4.1 The first saying

"Behold, I will send my messenger, and he shall prepare the way before me: and the LORD, whom ye seek, shall suddenly come to his temple, even the messenger of the covenant, whom ye delight in: behold, he shall come, saith the LORD of hosts" (Malachi 3:1). The sentence has two persons in it. The first is "my messenger," who prepares the way "before me," and the speaker is the LORD of hosts. The second is "the LORD, whom ye seek," who comes "to his temple," and who is called "the messenger of the covenant." The sentence promises a forerunner and the coming of the one he goes before, in one breath, and it names the place of the coming as the temple.

The Hebrew behind "my messenger" is the same word as the name of the book. Malachi 1:1 reads, "The burden of the word of the LORD to Israel by Malachi," and the name is the Hebrew form of "my messenger." The volume notes the fact and does not build on it. The book does not say that Malachi is the messenger of 3:1, and the Gospels do not say so either; they apply the sentence to John.

4.2 What follows the coming

The verses after 3:1 describe what the LORD's coming does. "But who may abide the day of his coming? and who shall stand when he appeareth? for he is like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' soap: and he shall sit as a refiner and purifier of silver: and he shall purify the sons of Levi, and purge them as gold and silver, that they may offer unto the LORD an offering in righteousness" (Malachi 3:2, 3). Then, "Then shall the offering of Judah and Jerusalem be pleasant unto the LORD, as in the days of old, and as in former years" (Malachi 3:4). And judgment: "And I will come near to you to judgment; and I will be a swift witness against the sorcerers, and against the adulterers, and against false swearers, and against those that oppress the hireling in his wages, the widow, and the fatherless" (Malachi 3:5).

The whole paragraph is addressed to the house of Levi and to Judah and Jerusalem, and it is about an offering made in righteousness at the temple. It is Israel's paragraph. The second volume of this series reads the charges against the priests; this chapter needs only the point that the coming of 3:1 is described in terms of a refining, a purifying of the sons of Levi, and a judgment, and that the Gospels do not report these things done when John came.

4.3 The Gospels quote the first half

Three Gospels quote Malachi 3:1, and each stops in the same place. Mark opens: "As it is written in the prophets, Behold, I send my messenger before thy face, which shall prepare thy way before thee" (Mark 1:2). The Lord says of John, "For this is he, of whom it is written, Behold, I send my messenger before thy face, which shall prepare thy way before thee" (Matthew 11:10; Luke 7:27). In all three the quotation ends at "before thee." None of them carries on to "and the LORD, whom ye seek, shall suddenly come to his temple."

Two differences from the Hebrew are visible in the Gospels' wording. The Gospels have "before thy face" and "thy way before thee," where Malachi has "before me." The volume reports the difference and does not explain it. What the volume takes from it is only that the speaker in the Gospels is addressing the Lord Jesus, and the sentence the Gospels quote is the half of Malachi 3:1 that is about the forerunner. The half that is about the coming to the temple is not quoted in any of the three places, and the volume does not add it for them.

4.4 The two sayings side by side

Malachi 3:1 and 4:5 can be read as one saying about one person, or as two sayings about two. The text does not decide it on its face, and both readings have been held. What the text shows is a difference of wording and of what follows. In 3:1 the sender calls the figure "my messenger" and the figure prepares "the way before me." In 4:5 he calls him "Elijah the prophet," and he comes "before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD." In 3:1 what follows is the coming of the LORD to his temple. In 4:5 what follows is the day.

Luke's account of the angel's word to Zacharias takes up both. Gabriel says of John, "he shall go before him in the spirit and power of Elias, to turn the hearts of the fathers to the children, and the disobedient to the wisdom of the just; to make ready a people prepared for the Lord" (Luke 1:17). The sentence has the "go before" of 3:1, the "Elias" of 4:5, and the turning of the hearts of 4:6, and it does not say that John is

Elias. It says that he goes "in the spirit and power of Elias." The volume reads the sentence in chapter 6.

Malachi's two sayings of a forerunner.

	Malachi 3:1	Malachi 4:5, 6
Who sends	The LORD of hosts	The LORD
Who is sent	"My messenger"	"Elijah the prophet"
What he does	Prepares the way before me	Turns the heart of the fathers to the children, and the children to the fathers
What follows	The LORD comes suddenly to his temple	The great and dreadful day of the LORD
What the Gospels quote	Mark 1:2; Matthew 11:10; Luke 7:27 (to "before thee")	Matthew 11:14 and 17:11, 12 name Elias; Luke 1:17 echoes 4:6

4.5 What the volume takes from the passages

- Malachi 3:1 speaks of a messenger and of the LORD who comes suddenly to his temple after him; Malachi 4:5 speaks of Elijah the prophet and of the day.
- The Gospels quote Malachi 3:1 only as far as "before thee," and apply it to John; they do not quote the half about the coming to the temple.
- The paragraph that follows Malachi 3:1 describes a refining of the sons of Levi and a judgment, and the Gospels do not report these done at John's coming.
- Luke 1:17 joins the "go before" of 3:1, the name of 4:5 and the turning of 4:6, and says "in the spirit and power of Elias," not "Elias."
- Whether 3:1 and 4:5 speak of one figure or two is not settled by the wording alone; the volume goes on to read what each Gospel does with the names.

5. The Voice in the Wilderness: Isaiah 40

Claim: the Gospels give John three descriptions drawn from Scripture, and they are different descriptions. One is Malachi's messenger, one is Isaiah's voice, and one is the spirit and power of Elias. Isaiah's voice is the only one John applies to himself in the Gospels, and he applies it without the title of Elijah. The chapter reads Isaiah 40:1–5 in its own place and then reads how each Gospel brings it to John, so that the reader can see what is claimed for John by Isaiah and what is not.

5.1 Isaiah's comfort

Isaiah 40 opens with a command to comfort: "Comfort ye, comfort ye my people, saith your God. Speak ye comfortably to Jerusalem, and cry unto her, that her warfare is accomplished, that her iniquity is pardoned: for she hath received of the LORD's hand double for all her sins" (Isaiah 40:1, 2). Then the voice: "The voice of him that crieth in the wilderness, Prepare ye the way of the LORD, make straight in the desert a highway for our God" (Isaiah 40:3). The preparation is of a highway, and the highway is for "our God." The valleys are lifted, the mountains made low, the crooked made

straight, and “the glory of the LORD shall be revealed, and all flesh shall see it together: for the mouth of the LORD hath spoken it” (Isaiah 40:4, 5).

The speaker of the passage is not named. It is “the voice of him that crieth,” and the next verses show other voices: “The voice said, Cry. And he said, What shall I cry?” (Isaiah 40:6). The prophet gives no name to the one who cries in the wilderness, and he does not say that he is Elijah or that he is anyone but a voice. The passage is addressed to Jerusalem, its comfort is Jerusalem’s comfort, and its end is the glory of the LORD revealed.

5.2 How the Gospels bring it to John

All four Gospels apply Isaiah 40:3 to John. Mark joins it to Malachi: “As it is written in the prophets, Behold, I send my messenger before thy face … The voice of one crying in the wilderness, Prepare ye the way of the Lord, make his paths straight” (Mark 1:2, 3). The King James text prints “in the prophets,” and the quotation that follows is from two of them, Malachi and Isaiah. Matthew writes, “For this is he that was spoken of by the prophet Esaias, saying, The voice of one crying in the wilderness, Prepare ye the way of the Lord, make his paths straight” (Matthew 3:3). Luke carries on further into Isaiah: “Every valley shall be filled, and every mountain and hill shall be brought low; and the crooked shall be made straight, and the rough ways shall be made smooth; and all flesh shall see the salvation of God” (Luke 3:5, 6). Luke’s setting is dated by rulers: the fifteenth year of Tiberius Caesar, Pontius Pilate governor, “Annas and Caiaphas being the high priests,” and then, “the word of God came unto John the son of Zacharias in the wilderness” (Luke 3:1, 2).

John himself, in the fourth Gospel, uses the passage for himself when he is asked who he is: “I am the voice of one crying in the wilderness, Make straight the way of the Lord, as said the prophet Esaias” (John 1:23). This is the only place in the Gospels where John answers the question of who he is with a text of Scripture, and the text is Isaiah’s. He does not answer with Malachi 3:1 and he does not answer with Malachi 4:5.

5.3 What John preached and who came

The Gospels describe the message in the same terms. “In those days came John the Baptist, preaching in the wilderness of Judaea, and saying, Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand” (Matthew 3:1, 2). Mark says, “John did baptize in the wilderness, and preach the baptism of repentance for the remission of sins” (Mark 1:4), and then, “there went out unto him all the land of Judaea, and they of Jerusalem, and were all baptized of him in the river of Jordan, confessing their sins” (Mark 1:5). Matthew says, “Then went out to him Jerusalem, and all Judaea, and all the region round about Jordan, and were baptized of him in Jordan, confessing their sins” (Matthew 3:5, 6).

The message and its audience are Israel’s. “All the land of Judaea, and they of Jerusalem” is the audience of Isaiah’s “comfort ye my people” and “speak ye comfortably to Jerusalem.” The call is to repent because the kingdom of heaven is at hand, and the kingdom is the one the prophets had announced to Israel. The volume reads the passages in this setting and does not carry the message of John over to anyone else. It is a message to Israel from a prophet of Israel about the kingdom, and its baptism is “the baptism of repentance.”

5.4 Mark's two words and John's dress

Mark describes John: "John was clothed with camel's hair, and with a girdle of a skin about his loins; and he did eat locusts and wild honey" (Mark 1:6). Matthew has "his raiment of camel's hair, and a leathern girdle about his loins" (Matthew 3:4). Chapter 2 put beside this the description given to Ahaziah of the man who met his messengers, "an hairy man, and girt with a girdle of leather about his loins" (2 Kings 1:8). The likeness is in the girdle of leather and the rough dress. The Gospels do not say that John dressed so in order to be taken for Elijah, and they do not draw the comparison. The comparison is the reader's, and the volume offers it only as a likeness of the text's wording, one that fits the sentence of Luke 1:17 and settles nothing alone.

How the Gospels describe John from Scripture.

Description	Source	Who applies it
My messenger, to prepare the way	Malachi 3:1	The Lord (Matthew 11:10; Luke 7:27); Mark 1:2
The voice of one crying in the wilderness	Isaiah 40:3	Matthew 3:3; Mark 1:3; Luke 3:4; John himself (John 1:23)
In the spirit and power of Elias	Malachi 4:5, 6 echoed	Gabriel (Luke 1:17)
Elias, if ye will receive it	Malachi 4:5	The Lord (Matthew 11:14)
Not Elias	Malachi 4:5	John (John 1:21)

5.5 What the volume takes from the passages

- Isaiah 40:3 speaks of a voice crying in the wilderness and a highway prepared for "our God"; the voice is anonymous and the comfort is Jerusalem's.
- All four Gospels apply Isaiah 40:3 to John, and John applies it to himself in John 1:23.
- John answers the question of who he is with Isaiah's voice and not with a title of Elijah.
- John's preaching and baptism are to Israel: "all the land of Judaea, and they of Jerusalem."
- The likeness between John's dress and Elijah's is in the wording of the text and is noted without being pressed.

6. Gabriel's Word: Luke 1

Claim: the first New Testament voice on Malachi's promise is the angel's, and it is carefully worded. Gabriel says that a son of Zacharias will go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elias." He does not say that the son will be Elias. He quotes part of Malachi 4:6 and puts the rest in other words, and he says nothing of the day or the curse. The chapter reads the whole passage in its priestly setting and then reads Zacharias's song, so that the reader can see what the household of John believed the promise to mean.

6.1 A priest's house

Luke opens in the days of Herod, "a certain priest named Zacharias, of the course of Abia: and his wife was of the daughters of Aaron, and her name was Elisabeth" (Luke 1:5). They were "righteous before God, walking in all the commandments and ordinances of the Lord blameless" (Luke 1:6), and had no child. The setting is the temple at the hour of incense, with "the whole multitude of the people … praying without" (Luke 1:10), and the angel stands "on the right side of the altar of incense" (Luke 1:11). It is the temple of Malachi 3:1, with a priest of the sons of Levi at its altar, and the people outside.

The angel's words are these: "Fear not, Zacharias: for thy prayer is heard; and thy wife Elisabeth shall bear thee a son, and thou shalt call his name John" (Luke 1:13). The son is to be "great in the sight of the Lord," abstaining from wine and strong drink, "filled with the Holy Ghost, even from his mother's womb" (Luke 1:15). The filling with the Spirit is said of John from the womb, and the volume reports it and leaves it there.

6.2 Many of the children of Israel

Then the work: "And many of the children of Israel shall he turn to the Lord their God" (Luke 1:16). The audience is Israel, and the number is "many." Gabriel does not say "all," which is the word Mark and Matthew use of the crowds who went to the Jordan, and the volume does not make the difference larger than the words allow. The turning is "to the Lord their God," which is the direction of Elijah's prayer on Carmel in chapter 2.

Verse 17 follows: "And he shall go before him in the spirit and power of Elias, to turn the hearts of the fathers to the children, and the disobedient to the wisdom of the just; to make ready a people prepared for the Lord." Four things are said. He goes "before him," and the pronoun's antecedent is "the Lord their God" of the verse before. He goes "in the spirit and power of Elias," which is the form of 2 Kings 2:15, "the spirit of Elijah doth rest on Elisha." His work is "to turn the hearts of the fathers to the children," which is half of Malachi 4:6, with "the disobedient to the wisdom of the just" in place of the second half. And the purpose is "to make ready a people prepared for the Lord."

6.3 What Gabriel leaves out

Three omissions are plain. Gabriel does not say that John is Elias. He does not quote the second half of Malachi 4:6, "lest I come and smite the earth with a curse," and he does not mention the day. And he does not say that John restores all things. The sentence is a statement of John's office in terms of Elijah's spirit and power, and the aim is a prepared people. A reader who hears in it the whole of Malachi 4:5, 6 hears more than the sentence says. A reader who hears in it nothing of Malachi hears less.

The Elisha precedent of chapter 3 is the clearest guide to the form. In Kings the prophets said of Elisha, "The spirit of Elijah doth rest on Elisha" (2 Kings 2:15), and Elisha was not called Elijah. In Luke the angel says of John that he will go "in the spirit and power of Elias," and John is not called Elias. The volume does not say that the two cases are the same. It says that the form of words is one the Old Testament had already used of a man who was not the man named, and that the form tells a reader to expect a man who bears Elijah's spirit and power.

6.4 Zacharias's song

When the child is born, Zacharias "was filled with the Holy Ghost, and prophesied" (Luke 1:67). The song is in Israel's covenant terms: "Blessed be the Lord God of Israel; for he hath visited and redeemed his people, and hath raised up an horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David; as he spake by the mouth of his holy prophets, which have been since the world began" (Luke 1:68–70). The aim is "to perform the mercy promised to our fathers, and to remember his holy covenant; the oath which he sware to our father Abraham" (Luke 1:72, 73), and the salvation is "from our enemies, and from the hand of all that hate us" (Luke 1:71).

Then he turns to the child: "And thou, child, shalt be called the prophet of the Highest: for thou shalt go before the face of the Lord to prepare his ways; to give knowledge of salvation unto his people by the remission of their sins, through the tender mercy of our God; whereby the dayspring from on high hath visited us" (Luke 1:76–78). The father calls the son "the prophet of the Highest." He does not call him Elias. The child's work is to "prepare his ways" and to "give knowledge of salvation unto his people." The setting of the song is the house of David, the covenant with Abraham, and the people Israel, and the volume reads John in that setting.

What Luke 1 says of John and Elias.

Verse	What is said	What is not said
1:16	Many of the children of Israel will be turned to the Lord their God	That all will be; that the day comes
1:17	Goes before him in the spirit and power of Elias; turns the hearts of the fathers to the children	That he is Elias; the curse; the day; the restoring of all things
1:17	To make ready a people prepared for the Lord	That the people are made ready
1:76	"The prophet of the Highest," going before the face of the Lord	That he is called Elias
1:68–73	The song speaks of David, the covenant and Abraham	Any word about the nations or a heavenly calling

6.5 What the volume takes from the passages

- Gabriel says John will go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elias," a form the Old Testament used of Elisha.
- Luke 1:16, 17 is addressed to Israel and states a purpose, a people prepared, without reporting that the purpose was met.
- Gabriel quotes part of Malachi 4:6 and says nothing of the curse or the day, and does not say that John restores all things.
- Zacharias calls his son "the prophet of the Highest," and the song is in the terms of David, Abraham and the covenant with Israel.
- Nothing in Luke 1 identifies John as Malachi's Elijah the prophet; what it describes is a man who bears Elijah's spirit and power.

7. John’s Answer: “I Am Not”

Claim: John the Baptist, asked directly whether he is Elias, says, “I am not.” The statement is in the Gospels and it is John’s own. The volume does not set it aside and does not set it against the Lord’s words in chapter 8. It reads the scene in John 1 as written, with its questioners, its three denials and the text John gives for himself, and then reads the second scene in John 3 where John speaks of his own place and his decrease. The aim is to record exactly what John says, to whom, and what he does not say.

7.1 The deputation

“And this is the record of John, when the Jews sent priests and Levites from Jerusalem to ask him, Who art thou?” (John 1:19). The questioners are priests and Levites, and the sender is “the Jews” from Jerusalem. The text adds a detail a few verses on: “And they which were sent were of the Pharisees” (John 1:24). The deputation is official and from the temple city. Its question is short, and the answers come one at a time.

John’s first answer is a denial of the highest title: “And he confessed, and denied not; but confessed, I am not the Christ” (John 1:20). The verbs are emphatic, “confessed, and denied not,” and the answer is to a question that has not yet been asked in so many words. The next question is the one this volume follows: “And they asked him, What then? Art thou Elias? And he saith, I am not. Art thou that prophet? And he answered, No” (John 1:21). Three questions, three denials. The Christ, Elias and “that prophet” are three expected figures, and John is none of them. The questioners reached for the second title on their own.

7.2 What the questioners expected

The priests and Levites ask, “Art thou Elias?” and the question shows that Elias was an expected figure in Jerusalem. The question fits Malachi 4:5, and the questioners’ expectation, in the form the text records, is that Elias is a figure who is to come and may be recognized. The question does not say how they conceived him, a returned Tishbite or a prophet like him. The text records the question and the answer and gives no more. The volume does not supply what they thought.

When they ask again, “Who art thou? that we may give an answer to them that sent us. What sayest thou of thyself?” (John 1:22), John does not offer another title from Malachi. He answers, “I am the voice of one crying in the wilderness, Make straight the way of the Lord, as said the prophet Esaias” (John 1:23). The text he gives for himself is Isaiah’s, as chapter 5 showed. The deputation then asks the question that follows from his answers: “Why baptizest thou then, if thou be not that Christ, nor Elias, neither that prophet?” (John 1:25). They treat baptizing as a right of one of the three, and John does not dispute the connection. He points past himself: “I baptize with water: but there standeth one among you, whom ye know not; he it is, who coming after me is preferred before me, whose shoe’s latchet I am not worthy to unloose” (John 1:26, 27).

7.3 What “I am not” says and does not say

The words “I am not” answer the question the priests asked, in the sense they asked it. They are John’s statement about himself. Taken as written they say that John,

asked whether he is Elias, says no. They do not say that Malachi's promise has no further fulfilment, and they do not say that John's ministry had nothing to do with Elijah. John does not discuss Malachi 4:5. He does not say that Elias is yet to come, and he does not say that Elias has come in him. The scene carries a single question and a single answer, and the volume reads it with the same restraint.

The volume sets one more fact beside it. Gabriel's sentence in Luke 1:17 does not call John Elias, and John's answer in John 1:21 does not either. The two statements agree in this: neither uses the title for John. What the Lord says of him in Matthew 11:14 is read in the next chapter in its own setting. The volume does not reconcile John 1:21 with Matthew 11:14 beyond what the passages state, and the reader is told so here so as not to expect it.

7.4 John 3: the friend of the bridegroom

A second scene shows John speaking of his place. A question arises between John's disciples and a Jew about purifying, and the disciples come to John with a grievance: "Rabbi, he that was with thee beyond Jordan, to whom thou barest witness, behold, the same baptizeth, and all men come to him" (John 3:26). John answers, "A man can receive nothing, except it be given him from heaven. Ye yourselves bear me witness, that I said, I am not the Christ, but that I am sent before him" (John 3:27, 28). The phrase "sent before him" is the nearest John comes to the language of Malachi 3:1, "I will send my messenger."

Then the figure of the wedding: "He that hath the bride is the bridegroom: but the friend of the bridegroom, which standeth and heareth him, rejoiceth greatly because of the bridegroom's voice: this my joy therefore is fulfilled. He must increase, but I must decrease" (John 3:29, 30). The bridegroom and the bride are read in Prophetic Identity Volume 1, and this volume does not repeat the reading. The point here is John's own account of his office. He is the friend who stands and hears, and his joy is full when the bridegroom's voice is heard. His decrease is the other side of the Lord's increase.

7.5 For a season

The Lord himself speaks of John's work as bounded. "Ye sent unto John, and he bare witness unto the truth. But I receive not testimony from man: but these things I say, that ye might be saved. He was a burning and a shining light: and ye were willing for a season to rejoice in his light" (John 5:33–35). The verb is past, "he was," and the time is limited, "for a season." The audience is the Jerusalem leadership that had sent to John, the same company John 1:19 describes. The volume notes the Lord's phrase because it frames what John's ministry was: a light the leaders were willing to rejoice in for a season. It was not all they were told it could be.

John's statements about himself.

Passage	What John says	Of whom or what
John 1:20	"I am not the Christ"	The first title offered
John 1:21	"I am not" (Elias); "No" (that prophet)	The second and third titles

Passage	What John says	Of whom or what
John 1:23	“I am the voice of one crying in the wilderness”	Isaiah 40:3
John 1:26, 27	“There standeth one among you, whom ye know not”	The one coming after him
John 3:28	“I am not the Christ, but … I am sent before him”	His own office
John 3:29, 30	The friend of the bridegroom; “He must increase, but I must decrease”	His place beside the bridegroom

7.6 What the volume takes from the passages

- Asked by priests and Levites of the Pharisees whether he is Elias, John says, “I am not.”
- John answers the question of who he is with Isaiah 40:3, not with a title from Malachi.
- John says he is “sent before” the Christ, and calls himself the friend of the bridegroom whose joy is full at the bridegroom’s voice.
- John 1:21 does not discuss Malachi 4:5, and says neither that Elias is yet to come nor that Elias has come in him.
- The volume reads John 1:21 as written and does not reconcile it with Matthew 11:14 beyond the text.

8. The Lord’s Answer About John

Claim: when the Lord speaks of John, he says three things that the volume holds side by side. John is “more than a prophet” and the messenger of Malachi 3:1. John is Elias “if ye will receive it.” And this generation refused both John and the Son of man. The first two are said in one sitting, and the third follows at once. The chapter reads Matthew 11 and Luke 7 in order, with the question that John asked from prison, the answer the Lord gave to John’s disciples, and the words the Lord then spoke to the crowds.

8.1 The question from prison

“Now when John had heard in the prison the works of Christ, he sent two of his disciples, and said unto him, Art thou he that should come, or do we look for another?” (Matthew 11:2, 3). Luke tells the same story at greater length, with the disciples repeating the question to the Lord (Luke 7:19, 20). The question is John’s, from prison, about the Lord. The words “he that should come” echo the language of the coming one, and the volume does not interpret John’s motive. The text gives the question and nothing of why it was asked.

The Lord’s answer is a list of works: “Go and shew John again those things which ye do hear and see” (Matthew 11:4), and the works follow: “The blind receive their sight, and the lame walk, the lepers are cleansed, and the deaf hear, the dead are raised up, and the poor have the gospel preached to them” (Matthew 11:5). Luke adds that in that same hour he “cured many of their infirmities and plagues, and of evil spirits” (Luke 7:21). The list is drawn from Isaiah’s pictures of the coming one: the blind

seeing and the lame walking (Isaiah 35:5, 6) and good tidings to the poor (Isaiah 61:1). The answer to "art thou he" is to point to what Isaiah said would be done. Then a word to John: "And blessed is he, whosoever shall not be offended in me" (Matthew 11:6).

8.2 More than a prophet

When the messengers have gone, the Lord turns to the multitudes. Three times he asks what they went out to see: "A reed shaken with the wind?" "A man clothed in soft raiment?" "A prophet?" (Matthew 11:7–9). The answer to the third question is "yea, I say unto you, and more than a prophet." Then the text: "For this is he, of whom it is written, Behold, I send my messenger before thy face, which shall prepare thy way before thee" (Matthew 11:10). Luke's form is "and much more than a prophet," with the same quotation (Luke 7:26, 27).

The Lord's application of Malachi 3:1 to John is complete and plain. The volume follows it. John is the messenger of whom Malachi wrote, and he prepared the way. In the sentence that follows the Lord says, "Among them that are born of women there hath not risen a greater than John the Baptist: notwithstanding he that is least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he" (Matthew 11:11). The saying about "the least in the kingdom" and the saying that follows about violence, "from the days of John the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven suffereth violence, and the violent take it by force" (Matthew 11:12), are read in Prophecy & Mystery Volume 3 and in the first volume of the Readers Question Series, and this volume cites them and does not argue them.

8.3 "If ye will receive it"

Then the sentences on which the whole question turns. "For all the prophets and the law prophesied until John. And if ye will receive it, this is Elias, which was for to come. He that hath ears to hear, let him hear" (Matthew 11:13–15). Luke's account does not carry these sentences. The statement is conditional, "if ye will receive it," and it is addressed to the multitudes. The clause "which was for to come" is in the past tense of expectation: Elias was the one who was to come. The Lord says that John is that Elias, on the condition that the hearers will receive it.

The condition is not decoration. A statement made on the condition of a hearer's reception is a statement about an offer. If the offer is received, John is Elias in the sense the Lord names. If it is not, the statement does not take effect in that sense, and the text will show in chapter 9 that the Lord speaks of Elias as one who "shall first come" after John has been put to death. The volume reads Matthew 11:14 as the Lord's offer to the nation, made in John's day, of the identification of John as the Elias of Malachi. It reads the offer as one the nation did not accept, and the next sentences confirm that.

8.4 This generation

The Lord goes on: "But whereunto shall I liken this generation? It is like unto children sitting in the markets, and calling unto their fellows, and saying, We have piped unto you, and ye have not danced; we have mourned unto you, and ye have not lamented. For John came neither eating nor drinking, and they say, He hath a devil. The Son of man came eating and drinking, and they say, Behold a man gluttonous, and a winebibber, a friend of publicans and sinners" (Matthew 11:16–19). The generation

refused John for his austerity and the Son of man for his ease. Both messages were rejected.

Luke adds a verse on the division within the people: “And all the people that heard him, and the publicans, justified God, being baptized with the baptism of John. But the Pharisees and lawyers rejected the counsel of God against themselves, being not baptized of him” (Luke 7:29, 30). The people and the publicans justified God, and the Pharisees and lawyers rejected his counsel. The Pharisees are the company from which the deputation of John 1:24 came. The Gospel record shows a split: some received John, and the leaders refused him.

8.5 Two words, one scene

The chapter has now two statements about John from the Lord within a few lines. John is the messenger of Malachi 3:1, and John is Elias if the hearers will receive it. They are not the same sentence and the Lord does not merge them. The first is a statement of fact grounded in a text, “this is he, of whom it is written.” The second is a conditional about the hearers. The volume holds them as the Lord states them. It does not say that John failed or that the Lord withdrew an offer. It says that the Lord made one, and that the generation he describes in verses 16–19 did not take it.

The Lord’s statements about John.

Passage	What the Lord says	The form
Matthew 11:9	A prophet, “and more than a prophet”	A statement
Matthew 11:10; Luke 7:27	“This is he, of whom it is written, Behold, I send my messenger”	A text applied: Malachi 3:1
Matthew 11:11; Luke 7:28	None greater among those born of women; the least in the kingdom greater	A comparison
Matthew 11:14	“If ye will receive it, this is Elias, which was for to come”	A conditional offer
Matthew 11:16–19; Luke 7:31–35	This generation refused John and the Son of man	A rebuke
Luke 7:29, 30	The people and publicans justified God; the Pharisees and lawyers rejected his counsel	A division

8.6 What the volume takes from the passages

- John, from prison, asks whether the Lord is he that should come, and the Lord answers with works drawn from Isaiah and a word of blessing to the one not offended.
- The Lord applies Malachi 3:1 to John without qualification: “this is he, of whom it is written.”
- Matthew 11:14 is conditional: “if ye will receive it, this is Elias, which was for to come.” It is addressed to the multitudes and is not in Luke’s account.

- The generation the Lord describes refused both John and the Son of man; Luke records the split between the people and the Pharisees and lawyers.
- The volume reads Matthew 11:14 as an offer made to Israel in John's day and not taken up, and reads the Lord's words in Matthew 17 in the next chapter.

9. The Mountain and the Question: Matthew 17 and Mark 9

Claim: on the way down from the mountain the disciples ask about Elias, and the Lord answers with two sentences that look in opposite directions. "Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things" is in the future. "Elias is come already, and they knew him not" is in the past. Mark gives the same pair in the present and the past. The chapter reads the whole scene in order, the mountain, the question and the answer, and records what each sentence says before the next chapter asks what the pair means together.

9.1 Elias on the mountain

Six days after the confession at Caesarea Philippi, "Jesus taketh Peter, James, and John his brother, and bringeth them up into an high mountain apart, and was transfigured before them: and his face did shine as the sun, and his raiment was white as the light" (Matthew 17:1, 2). Then: "And, behold, there appeared unto them Moses and Elias talking with him" (Matthew 17:3). Mark gives the order the other way: "And there appeared unto them Elias with Moses: and they were talking with Jesus" (Mark 9:4). Moses and Elias are named, they are seen and they talk with the Lord. The text does not say how the disciples knew them, and it does not say what was said.

Peter answers, "Lord, it is good for us to be here: if thou wilt, let us make here three tabernacles; one for thee, and one for Moses, and one for Elias" (Matthew 17:4). Mark adds, "For he wist not what to say; for they were sore afraid" (Mark 9:6). A voice out of the cloud says, "This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased; hear ye him" (Matthew 17:5), and when the disciples lift their eyes, "they saw no man, save Jesus only" (Matthew 17:8). Moses stands for the law and Elias for the prophets in the common reading, and the text does not say so. The volume notes what is said: two named men, one of whom is Elias, appeared with the Lord on the mountain, and the voice named the Lord alone as the one to hear.

9.2 The charge and the question

"And as they came down from the mountain, Jesus charged them, saying, Tell the vision to no man, until the Son of man be risen again from the dead" (Matthew 17:9). Mark adds that "they kept that saying with themselves, questioning one with another what the rising from the dead should mean" (Mark 9:10). The charge is silence until the resurrection, and the disciples puzzle over the words. Then the question comes: "Why then say the scribes that Elias must first come?" (Matthew 17:10). Mark's form is "Why say the scribes that Elias must first come?" (Mark 9:11).

The question has a premise and a puzzle. The premise is that the scribes teach that Elias must first come, and the Lord does not dispute the teaching. The puzzle is the word "then." The disciples have just seen Elias with the Lord, and they have heard the Lord speak of rising from the dead. Their question asks how the scribes' teaching,

that Elias must first come, fits what they have seen. The text does not tell us what they had in mind, and the volume does not guess.

9.3 The two answers

"And Jesus answered and said unto them, Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things" (Matthew 17:11). The verb is future, "shall … come," and the sentence carries the word "truly" and a second work, "restore all things." Mark's form is present: "Elias verily cometh first, and restoreth all things" (Mark 9:12). In both, the Lord affirms the scribes' teaching. He does not say they are mistaken. He says that Elias comes first and restores all things.

Then: "But I say unto you, That Elias is come already, and they knew him not, but have done unto him whatsoever they listed. Likewise shall also the Son of man suffer of them" (Matthew 17:12). Mark's form: "But I say unto you, That Elias is indeed come, and they have done unto him whatsoever they listed, as it is written of him" (Mark 9:13). The sentence changes the tense and adds an adversative, "But I say unto you." Elias "is come already." The verb is past, the people "knew him not," and what they did to him is what the Son of man will suffer. Then Matthew adds: "Then the disciples understood that he spake unto them of John the Baptist" (Matthew 17:13).

9.4 What the sentences say

Five features of the text are plain. First, the Lord affirms the scribes' teaching: Elias "truly shall first come." Second, he adds a work that is not in Malachi's wording of 4:5, 6, "restore all things." Third, he says that Elias "is come already," and the people "knew him not." Fourth, what was done to Elias is what the Son of man will suffer. Fifth, the disciples understood the second sentence to be about John the Baptist, and Matthew places that understanding after verse 12, not after verse 11.

The two sentences are joined by "But," and the volume notes what Matthew 17:13 attaches to John. It says that the disciples "understood that he spake unto them of John the Baptist." The "he spake" has the whole of what the Lord said as its object, and the verse can be read as attaching John to both sentences or to the second. The volume does not decide that on grammar. The difference between the two readings is the subject of the next chapter. Mark's "as it is written of him" (Mark 9:13) points to Scripture that records what was done to Elias. The nearest written account of suffering for Elijah is in Kings, where Jezebel seeks his life and he says, "I, even I only, am left; and they seek my life, to take it away" (1 Kings 19:10, 14). Mark does not name the passage, and the volume reports the nearest and builds no more.

9.5 Restitution in Acts

The Lord's phrase "restore all things" has a counterpart in Peter's sermon in the temple. "Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord; and he shall send Jesus Christ, which before was preached unto you: whom the heaven must receive until the times of restitution of all things, which God hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets since the world began" (Acts 3:19–21). The word "restitution" and the word "restore" are related in the Greek, and the volume reports that fact and does not rest an argument on it. The first volume of the Acts Commentary Series reads the sermon, and this volume cites it. What the passage says is that "the times of restitution of all things" lie ahead of Peter's hearers, that heaven must receive Jesus until then, and that the prophets spoke of it.

The Lord's two sentences on Elias.

	Matthew 17:11	Matthew 17:12
Tense	Future: "shall first come"	Past: "is come already"
Work	"Restore all things"	"They knew him not … whatsoever they listed"
Mark's form	Present: "cometh first, and restoreth all things" (9:12)	"Is indeed come … as it is written of him" (9:13)
Link	"But I say unto you" joins them	Likewise the Son of man will suffer of them
What the disciples understood	Matthew 17:13 attaches John to the pair	Said of John the Baptist

9.6 What the volume takes from the passages

- Elias appeared with Moses and the Lord on the mountain, and the voice named the Lord alone as the one to hear.
- Asked why the scribes say Elias must first come, the Lord affirms it: "Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things." Mark has the present, "cometh first, and restoreth all things."
- He then says, "Elias is come already, and they knew him not," and ties what was done to Elias to what the Son of man will suffer.
- Matthew 17:13 says the disciples understood that he spake of John the Baptist, and the volume does not settle on grammar whether that attaches to both sentences.
- "Restore all things" has no counterpart in Malachi's wording, and the nearest text is Acts 3:21, read in the Acts volume and cited here.

10. Who Do Men Say? The Crowds, Herod and the Cross

Claim: the Gospels keep three lists of what people said about Jesus, and in every list John and Elias appear as two separate persons. The lists come after John's death. At the cross the bystanders think the Lord calls for Elias and wait to see whether he will come. Between those two scenes the disciples ask the Lord to bring down fire as Elias did, and he rebukes them. The chapter reads these passages as written, in order. It does not use them to settle the question; it records what the texts show about how the people thought of Elias.

10.1 Herod and the three lists

Herod the tetrarch hears of the Lord's fame and says, "This is John the Baptist; he is risen from the dead; and therefore mighty works do shew forth themselves in him" (Matthew 14:1, 2). Mark records the same, and adds what others said: "Others said, That it is Elias. And others said, That it is a prophet, or as one of the prophets" (Mark 6:14, 15). Luke has it the same way: Herod "was perplexed, because that it was said

of some, that John was risen from the dead; and of some, that Elias had appeared; and of others, that one of the old prophets was risen again" (Luke 9:7, 8). Matthew has already told of John's end: "And he sent, and beheaded John in the prison" (Matthew 14:10). Herod's own verdict is, in Mark, "It is John, whom I beheaded: he is risen from the dead" (Mark 6:16).

Three positions stand side by side in the lists: John risen, Elias appeared, and one of the prophets. Elias is not John in this list. The people who say "Elias" are not the people who say "John," and Herod's group, who say John, are not the same as those who say Elias. The lists come after John's death, and the opinion that Elias had "appeared" stands as a separate opinion even though the one the Lord had called Elias in Matthew 11:14 had already been killed.

10.2 Caesarea Philippi

The Lord asks his disciples what men say. "Whom do men say that I the Son of man am? And they said, Some say that thou art John the Baptist: some, Elias; and others, Jeremias, or one of the prophets" (Matthew 16:13, 14). Mark: "John the Baptist: but some say, Elias; and others, One of the prophets" (Mark 8:28). Luke: "John the Baptist; but some say, Elias; and others say, that one of the old prophets is risen again" (Luke 9:19). The disciples report the list, and the Lord goes on to ask what they say. Peter answers, "The Christ of God" (Luke 9:20).

The wording is steady across the three accounts: John, Elias, a prophet. The disciples give the people's list without comment. The volume notes only that the list names Elias as a separate figure from John a second time, in a scene the Gospels place after John's death, and that the Lord does not correct the list in the passage.

10.3 The prophet and the Prophet

Two other titles appear in John. After the feeding of the multitude, "those men, when they had seen the miracle that Jesus did, said, This is of a truth that prophet that should come into the world" (John 6:14). At the feast, "Many of the people therefore, when they heard this saying, said, Of a truth this is the Prophet" (John 7:40). "That prophet" is the figure the deputation of John 1:21 asked John about, and he said, No. The volume names the figure and does not take up whom the title names. For the question of Elias, the point is that the people of the Gospels kept a list of expected figures, and Elias was on it.

10.4 At the cross

When the Lord cries from the cross, "Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani?" the bystanders mishear: "Some of them that stood there, when they heard that, said, This man calleth for Elias" (Matthew 27:46, 47). Mark has it, "Behold, he calleth Elias" (Mark 15:35). Then one runs with a sponge, and "the rest said, Let be, let us see whether Elias will come to save him" (Matthew 27:49). Mark's form is "let us see whether Elias will come to take him down" (Mark 15:36).

The bystanders' words are the last mention of Elias in the Gospels. They show that a crowd at the cross thought of Elias as a figure who might come to a man in distress, to save him, and who might be called. The text records their expectation and records that no one came. The volume does not interpret the crowd's belief. It reports that a belief in Elias's coming was present at the cross, in the days after John's death, in the mouths of those who stood by.

10.5 The fire refused

The last passage is the Samaritan village. “And it came to pass, when the time was come that he should be received up, he stedfastly set his face to go to Jerusalem, and sent messengers before his face: and they went, and entered into a village of the Samaritans, to make ready for him. And they did not receive him, because his face was as though he would go to Jerusalem” (Luke 9:51–53). Then: “And when his disciples James and John saw this, they said, Lord, wilt thou that we command fire to come down from heaven, and consume them, even as Elias did?” (Luke 9:54).

The disciples name Elias as a precedent, and the precedent is 2 Kings 1. The Lord “turned, and rebuked them, and said, Ye know not what manner of spirit ye are of. For the Son of man is not come to destroy men’s lives, but to save them” (Luke 9:55, 56). The answer does not deny that Elias called fire. It says that the disciples do not know what manner of spirit they are of, and that the Son of man has come to save. The passage shows what the disciples drew from the example of Elias and what the Lord refused. It does not identify anyone as Elias, and it does not discuss Malachi.

Who the people and the disciples said, and when.

Passage	Who is named	After John’s death?
Matthew 14:1–2; Mark 6:14–16; Luke 9:7–9	Herod: John risen; others: Elias, a prophet	Yes; Herod beheaded John
Matthew 16:13–14; Mark 8:27–28; Luke 9:18–20	John the Baptist; Elias; Jeremias or a prophet	Yes
John 6:14; 7:40	That prophet; the Prophet	Not stated
Matthew 27:46–49; Mark 15:34–36	The bystanders think he calls Elias and wait to see whether Elias will come	Yes
Luke 9:51–56	The disciples ask for fire “even as Elias did”; the Lord rebukes them	Not stated

10.6 What the volume takes from the passages

- In every list of what the people said, John and Elias are two persons, and the lists come after John was beheaded.
- Herod, the crowds and the disciples’ report all keep “Elias” as a separate opinion from “John the Baptist.”
- The bystanders at the cross thought the Lord called Elias and waited to see whether Elias would come to save him.
- James and John name Elias as a precedent for calling fire, and the Lord refuses the fire with the words “Ye know not what manner of spirit ye are of.”
- None of these passages says who Elias is; they show that expectation of Elias’s coming was alive in the people after John’s death.

11. “Shall First Come” and “Is Come Already”

Claim: the Lord’s two sentences in Matthew 17:11 and 17:12 are not a contradiction and are not one statement said twice. The first is about a coming still ahead when he spoke it, by a man who restores all things. The second is about a coming already past, by a man whom the people did not know and who suffered. The chapter holds that the text leads to a further coming of Elijah before the day of the LORD, in the line of Israel, and sets out the reasons in order: the order of events, the words of the Lord, the form of Gabriel’s sentence, the man on the mountain, and the passage in Revelation 11 that the volume cites and does not name.

11.1 What Malachi 4:5 fixes

Malachi’s promise has one time mark, and it is “before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD” (Malachi 4:5). Elijah is sent before the day. The promise does not say how long before, and it does not say that the sending is fulfilled in one lifetime or in one visit. The test the volume applies is the test of Malachi’s own sentence: what is it that must come first, and has the day come? The Gospels record that John came and preached and was put to death. They do not record that the great and dreadful day followed. A promise that Elijah comes before the day is met by a coming that precedes the day, and the day, in the Gospels and after them, has not come.

11.2 The order of events

Matthew tells of John’s death in chapter 14, three chapters before the Lord says “Elias truly shall first come” (Matthew 14:10; 17:11). The sentence is spoken after John has been beheaded. A speaker who says “shall first come” after the man in question has died is, on its plain reading, speaking of a coming still to be. If the Lord meant that John’s ministry had already accomplished the coming, the future tense would have no work to do, and the disciples, who had watched John’s ministry end, would have had no reason to ask. The question the disciples ask is also in the present, “say the scribes that Elias must first come,” and the Lord does not say that the scribes’ teaching has been met. He says that it is so.

The second sentence does not take back the first. It adds a fact: “Elias is come already, and they knew him not.” The adversative “But I say unto you” sets the second sentence against what the disciples might conclude from the first, that nothing has yet been done. The Lord corrects that conclusion. Something has been done, and it was not recognized. The volume holds both sentences in the order in which the Lord gave them, the first in the future and the second in the past.

11.3 The words “restore all things”

The work the Lord names is “restore all things.” Malachi 4:6 speaks of turning hearts, and the Lord’s phrase is wider. It speaks of everything. The Gospels do not report that John’s ministry restored all things. They report the opposite: a ministry of repentance that drew the crowds, that the leaders refused, and that ended in a prison and a beheading (Matthew 14:3–10). The Lord himself says of the generation that it refused both John and the Son of man (Matthew 11:16–19). The nation was not turned and the land was not restored. The Lord’s phrase has a counterpart in Peter’s word in the temple that the heaven must receive Jesus “until the times of restitution of all things, which God hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets since the world began”

(Acts 3:21). That restitution is spoken of as still ahead after the cross and the resurrection, and it is Israel's: Peter speaks to "ye men of Israel" (Acts 3:12) and to those who "are the children of the prophets, and of the covenant" (Acts 3:25). The volume reads the Lord's "restore all things" as the work of the coming that is still ahead.

11.4 The form of Gabriel's sentence

Gabriel's sentence has been read in chapter 6. Its form is the form the Old Testament used of Elisha, a man who bears another's spirit and is not that man. The sentence is "in the spirit and power of Elias," and not "as Elias." If the angel had meant that John would be Elijah, the Old Testament's own precedent for the form is against him; if he meant that John would do Elijah's work and bear Elijah's spirit, the form fits. The sentence thus implies a distinct man: the Elias whose spirit and power John bore. The volume reads Luke 1:17 as consistent with Matthew 17:11 for this reason. A man who goes before the Lord in Elijah's spirit stands in an order of such men, and the Elias himself is not that man.

The same point stands behind John's "I am not." John says that he is not Elias, and the Lord says that Elias is come already. Chapter 7 held that the volume does not reconcile the two statements beyond the text. What the volume adds here is that the statements fit a coming of Elias in the person of one who bore his spirit, and that this coming is not the whole of what the Lord calls "shall first come." John is Elias in the sense of Matthew 11:14, if the nation will receive it. John is not Elias in the sense of John 1:21, the person the priests asked about. Neither sentence needs to be rewritten for the reading, and neither is made to say more than it does.

11.5 The man on the mountain

On the mount of transfiguration, "there appeared unto them Moses and Elias talking with him" (Matthew 17:3). The text names a person, Elias, who appears, and in the same scene, a few verses later, the Lord speaks of Elias as one who "shall first come" and as one who "is come already." The disciples saw Elias. They did not take him for John, for John was dead and they were told afterwards that the Lord spoke of John. The volume does not build a theory on the appearance. It notes that in the same scene the Gospels name Elias as a person who appears, as one who comes first, and as one who has come, and that the three are not the same use of the name.

11.6 Revelation 11

The last text the volume sets beside the question is Revelation 11. "And I will give power unto my two witnesses, and they shall prophesy a thousand two hundred and threescore days, clothed in sackcloth" (Revelation 11:3). Then: "if any man will hurt them, fire proceedeth out of their mouth, and devoureth their enemies" (Revelation 11:5), and "These have power to shut heaven, that it rain not in the days of their prophecy" (Revelation 11:6). The next verses tell that the beast shall overcome them and kill them, that after three days and a half "the Spirit of life from God entered into them, and they stood upon their feet," and that they heard "a great voice from heaven saying unto them, Come up hither. And they ascended up to heaven in a cloud" (Revelation 11:7–12). The passage opens with the measuring of the temple and the holy city given to the Gentiles "forty and two months" (Revelation 11:1, 2).

The volume sets out the features and does not name the witnesses. The fire from the mouth is the fire of 2 Kings 1. The power to shut heaven is the power of 1 Kings 17:1.

The days, one thousand two hundred and threescore, are three years and a half by the count of thirty days to the month, the same span James gives to the shutting of the heaven in Elijah's day (James 5:17) and the Lord gives in Luke 4:25. The ascent into heaven in a cloud after a death is the end of a prophet's ministry, as the whirlwind was Elijah's. The setting is a temple at Jerusalem and a city given to the Gentiles, the setting of Malachi's own paragraphs, and the volume reads it as Israel's line. The passage does not call anyone Elijah, and the volume does not add the name. The Lord's two sentences say that Elias shall first come, and Revelation 11 shows prophets of Elijah's works in the days of the beast. The volume lays them side by side.

11.7 What the volume holds, and what it does not say

The position is this. Malachi 4:5 promises Elijah the prophet before the day of the LORD. John went before the Lord in his spirit and power and was, if the nation would receive it, Elias. The nation did not receive it, John was put to death, and the Lord spoke afterwards of Elias as one who shall first come and restore all things. The restoring is not reported done and the day has not come. The text therefore points to a further coming of Elijah before the day, in Israel's line, as the restorer. The Body of Christ is not read into any of these passages.

The volume does not say when this coming is. It does not say where. It does not say that the person who comes is the Tishbite of Kings in the flesh, and it does not say that he is another man in Elijah's spirit. It does not identify the witnesses of Revelation 11. It does not set a date for the day of the LORD, which is read in Study 7 and in the fifth volume of the Prophecy & Mystery Commentary Series. It does not say that every sentence about Elijah in the Gospels is about the further coming. The position is as large as the text allows and no larger.

The reasons for a further coming, in order.

Reason	Text	What it shows
The time mark	Malachi 4:5	Elijah before the day; the day has not come
The order of events	Matthew 14:10; 17:11	"Shall first come" is spoken after John's death
The work	Matthew 17:11; Acts 3:21	"Restore all things" is not reported done; restitution lies ahead
The form of Gabriel's sentence	Luke 1:17; 2 Kings 2:15	A man in Elijah's spirit, not Elijah
John's answer and the Lord's	John 1:21; Matthew 11:14	Two statements, each in its own setting, not made to agree beyond the text
The man on the mount	Matthew 17:3	Elias is a named person who appears
Elijah's works later	Revelation 11:3–12	Fire from the mouth, a shut heaven, the days, the ascent; set beside, not named

11.8 What the volume takes from the passages

- Malachi 4:5 puts Elijah “before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD,” and the day has not come.
- “Elias truly shall first come” is spoken after John’s death, and “restore all things” is not reported done by John’s ministry; Acts 3:21 speaks of restitution as still ahead.
- “Elias is come already” is a second fact set against the first, and John’s “I am not” and the Lord’s “this is Elias” are each read in their own setting.
- Luke 1:17 uses the form the Old Testament used of Elisha, which implies a distinct man whose spirit and power John bore.
- The text points to a further coming of Elijah before the day, in Israel’s line; Revelation 11 is cited beside it and its witnesses are not named.

12. Objections and Replies

Claim: the volume’s reading, that Malachi promises one Elijah, that John came in his spirit and power and was Elias if the nation would receive it, and that the text points to a further coming before the day, answers the objections best made against it, and where an objector is right the volume says so. Modern writers who hold parts of the position are named beside those who press against it. A writer is quoted only where the author has read the words in a free text. A writer’s view is described in the volume’s own words when only a summary of it was read, and no quotation marks are used for it.

12.1 Who agrees, and where the volume differs

Three modern writers hold that Malachi’s promise has a coming still ahead. Thomas Ice, in an article titled “Elijah is Coming” published by the Pre-Trib Research Center in 2018, writes, “So Elijah is still to come.” He holds that the promise was offered to Israel in John’s day and not taken up. His sentence, “John the Baptist fulfilled a different prediction, that of Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3-5,” keeps the two sayings of chapter 4 apart, as this volume does. He also writes that “because of Israel’s rejection, John the Baptist was John the Baptist (My messenger) and not Elijah.” The volume agrees on the offer and its refusal and on the two sayings. It differs in two respects. Ice places the coming in the tribulation, and this volume says only that the coming is before the day of the LORD, and it does not name the period. And Ice’s article reads the coming of Elijah as a visit by Elijah himself, while the volume leaves open whether the one who comes is the Tishbite or a man in his spirit.

Walter C. Kaiser Jr., in an article in *Grace Theological Journal* in 1982 titled “The Promise of the Arrival of Elijah in Malachi and the Gospels,” sets out three ways to read the promise. The first is that John fully fulfilled it. The second is that the Tishbite returns in person. The third is that John came in Elijah’s spirit and power as one of a series of forerunners. Kaiser holds the third. He writes that “John then was Elijah as an earnest, but we still await the other Elijahs.” He also argues that a present-tense verb in the Lord’s sentence is, in his words, a “futuristic present,” because “this present is coupled with a future tense.” The volume agrees that John came as an earnest, to use Kaiser’s word, and that the Lord’s sentences look ahead. It differs in not adopting his series. The volume asks what the Gospels say about the Elijah of

Malachi 4:5 and holds one further coming before the day; it does not say that Scripture lists a line of forerunners.

Paul Henebury, in an article titled “John the Baptist and Elijah” on the SharperIron site in 2021, grants the point many make and denies the conclusion drawn from it. He writes, “Many scholars have argued that the fulfillment of the Elijah prophecy (of Mal. 4:5), is to be confined to John the Baptist.” His answer is, “But this does not force us to conclude that there is no future work for Elijah to do.” He goes on to write, “At the second coming of Messiah as Conqueror and King, Elijah himself returns to prepare the way.” The volume agrees that a work remains. It differs by not tying the coming to the Messiah’s return as a date, since no passage says so, and by not saying that the person is Elijah himself. The three writers support the shape of the position and none of them is quoted for more than they say.

12.2 Objection: Malachi speaks of an office, and John filled it

The strongest opposing reading holds that Malachi’s Elijah is John. Angus Stewart, in an address titled “The Coming of Elijah” given at the Covenant Protestant Reformed Church in 2004, writes, “Elijah in our text is John the Baptist, not the literal Tishbite revived.” His reason is that “Malachi 4:5 speaks of Elijah’s office rather than His person,” and he adds, “Similarly, Malachi is not prophesying that Elijah will return and labour again.” His sentence of the pattern is “Rather, one like Elijah will do a work like Elijah.” An unsigned devotional in the Ligonier Ministries series *Tabletalk* takes the same side. It writes, “However, Malachi did not predict a return of the very same Elijah in the flesh.” The objection is that the promise is met by a man in Elijah’s office, and John was that man.

Reply. The volume grants three things. First, a man in Elijah’s office or in his spirit and power is what Luke 1:17 says of John, and the volume has read it so. Second, the promise does not require that the Tishbite himself come, and the volume does not say that he does. Third, the devotional is right about the people of John’s day: it writes, “The Jews were expecting a literal return of Elijah, and in that respect, John the Baptist certainly was not Elijah,” which is what John says in John 1:21. The volume parts from the objection at one point. The office reading says that the promise is closed because John held the office. The Lord’s sentence, “Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things” (Matthew 17:11), is spoken after John’s death, and the restoring is not reported done. If the office was filled by John and the promise closed, the future tense of the Lord’s sentence has no work to do. A man may fill an office in the sense of Matthew 11:14 and the office may be filled again before the day.

12.3 Objection: “Elias is come already” settles it

The objection reads the second sentence of Matthew 17:12 as the Lord’s last word: Elias is come already, the disciples understood that he spake of John, and the matter is closed. Mark’s form, “Elias is indeed come” (Mark 9:13), is read the same way. Reply. The sentence is the second of a pair, and the pair begins, “Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things.” The Lord does not say that Elias has come and that the scribes are therefore wrong. He says that the scribes’ teaching is true, and then he says “But I say unto you” that Elias is come already and they knew him not. A reader who takes only the second sentence takes half of what the Lord said, and a reader who takes only the first takes the other half. The volume holds both in the order in which they were spoken. Matthew 17:13 says that the disciples understood that he

spake unto them of John, and the volume reports that the verse comes after both sentences.

12.4 Objection: a further coming adds what Jesus did not say

A reader may say that the volume adds to the Gospels a coming the Lord never described. No writer is named for this; it is the volume's own statement of the worry. Reply. The Lord said that Elias "shall first come, and restore all things," and the volume takes the sentence at its word. What the volume adds is two observations drawn from the text: the sentence was spoken after John's death, and the restoring is not reported done. It adds no date, no place, no name, no description of the coming beyond what Malachi and the Lord say. The charge of adding applies with equal force to a reading that says the promise is closed, for that reading adds that the future tense of Matthew 17:11 is a figure for something already past.

12.5 Objection: "restore all things" is John's preaching

Another reader may say that "restore all things" describes what John's preaching did, calling the nation to repentance. No writer is named. Reply. The Gospels describe John's preaching as a call to repent, with crowds going out to him (Matthew 3:5, 6), and they describe the leaders refusing it (Luke 7:30), and the Lord says that "this generation" refused both John and the Son of man (Matthew 11:16–19). They do not report that all things were restored. Peter, after the cross, speaks of restitution as ahead, "until the times of restitution of all things" (Acts 3:21). The volume takes the Lord's phrase to be as wide as it sounds, and reports that the Gospels do not say it was met.

12.6 Objection: John 1:21 and Matthew 11:14 contradict

A last objection says that if John says "I am not" and the Lord says "this is Elias," one of them is wrong. No writer is named. Reply. The two statements are each made in a setting. John answers priests and Levites of the Pharisees who ask a question about a figure they expected (John 1:19–25). The Lord speaks to the multitudes and makes his statement conditional: "if ye will receive it" (Matthew 11:14). The volume has not argued that the two statements are the same statement. It has said that neither is made to say more than it says, and that neither needs to be rewritten for the reading to stand. If the reader holds that they conflict, the reading of this volume does not depend on resolving the conflict, since the further coming does not rest on either sentence alone.

The objections and the replies in one table.

Objection	Held by	Reply in one line
Malachi speaks of an office, and John filled it	Stewart (2004); the Tabletalk devotional	Granted for Luke 1:17; the future tense of Matthew 17:11 is spoken after John's death
"Elias is come already" settles it	A common reading; none named	It is the second of a pair that begins "shall first come"
A further coming adds what Jesus did not say	none named	The Lord said "shall first come"; the volume adds no date, place or name

Objection	Held by	Reply in one line
"Restore all things" is John's preaching	none named	The Gospels do not report all things restored; Acts 3:21 speaks of restitution as ahead
John 1:21 and Matthew 11:14 contradict	none named	Each is read in its own setting; the reading does not rest on resolving them
The promise is a further coming, as the volume holds	Ice (2018); Kaiser (1982); Henebury (2021), in part	Agreed in shape; the volume differs on the period, the person and any series

12.7 What the volume takes from the replies

- Ice, Kaiser and Henebury hold that a work of Elijah remains; the volume agrees in shape and differs on the period, the person and any series of forerunners.
- Stewart and the Tabletalk devotional are right that Luke 1:17 speaks of an office and a spirit, and right that John was not the returned Tishbite in the people's sense.
- The office reading does not account for the future tense of Matthew 17:11 spoken after John's death.
- "Elias is come already" is the second of a pair; the first sentence is "Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things."
- John 1:21 and Matthew 11:14 are each read in their own setting, and the position does not rest on resolving them.

Conclusion

The volume began with a plain statement: it argues a position. The position is that Malachi promises one Elijah the prophet before the day of the LORD, that the Gospels answer in three voices, and that the text points to a further coming. Gabriel says that John will go before the Lord in the spirit and power of Elias. John, asked by priests and Levites whether he is Elias, says, "I am not." The Lord says, "if ye will receive it, this is Elias, which was for to come," and after John's death says, "Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things," and then, "Elias is come already, and they knew him not." The three voices are three statements made in three settings, and the volume has held each in its own place.

It has read the offer of Matthew 11:14 as a conditional one made to Israel in John's day. It has read the refusal in the verses that follow, where this generation is likened to children who would neither dance nor mourn, and in the end of John in the prison. It has read the restoring of all things as work not reported done, and the day of the LORD as not yet come. The text therefore points to a further coming of Elijah before the day, in Israel's line, as the restorer. The volume has set Revelation 11 beside the position and listed what the chapter itself says, and it has not named the witnesses. It has not read the Body of Christ into any of the passages.

The position in one table.

Question	The position	Chief passages
Who is promised?	Elijah the prophet, sent before the great and dreadful day of the LORD	Mal 4:5, 6
Who is the messenger of Malachi 3:1?	John, as the Lord applies the text; the paragraph after it is not reported met	Mal 3:1–5; Matt 11:10; Luke 7:27
What did Gabriel say?	John goes before the Lord in the spirit and power of Elias, to turn hearts and make ready a people	Luke 1:16, 17; 2 Kings 2:15
What did John say?	"I am not" to the priests and Levites; he is the voice of Isaiah 40:3	John 1:19–28; 3:28–30
What did the Lord say?	"If ye will receive it, this is Elias"; Elias shall first come and restore all things; Elias is come already	Matt 11:14; 17:11, 12; Mark 9:12, 13
Was the restoring done?	It is not reported done; restitution is spoken of as ahead	Acts 3:21
What do the people's lists show?	John and Elias stand as two persons after John's death	Matt 14:1, 2; 16:13, 14; 27:47–49
What follows?	A further coming of Elijah before the day, in Israel's line; the witnesses are not named	Mal 4:5; Rev 11:3–12

The volume asks to be tested. A reader who disagrees may take any row of the table and look for the verse that overturns it. If the verse is there, the position must change. If it is not, the position stands on what the text says.

It has tried to be fair to the readings it opposes. It has granted that Luke 1:17 speaks of an office and a spirit, that John was not the returned Tishbite in the sense the priests asked about, and that the Lord's "Elias is come already" is a real statement and not to be set aside. It has named three writers who hold that a work of Elijah remains, and said where it parts from each, and two sources that hold the promise closed in John, and said where it agrees and where it does not. What it hopes the reader takes away is a habit: when the Lord says two things about one name, to read both in the order he said them, and to ask of each what it says, to whom, and when.

Appendix A. The Passages at a Glance

Each passage on Elijah and John, who speaks, and what it states.

Passage	Who speaks	What it states
Malachi 3:1–5	The LORD of hosts	A messenger before me; the LORD comes to his temple; a refining
Malachi 4:4–6	The LORD	Law of Moses in Horeb; Elijah before the day; hearts turned; the curse
1 Kings 17–19, 21	The narrator; Elijah	The shut heaven, the widow's son, Carmel, Horeb, Naboth
2 Kings 1; 2	Narrator; sons of the prophets	Fire on captains; the whirlwind; "The spirit of Elijah doth rest on Elisha"
Isaiah 40:1–5	The LORD; a voice	Comfort for Jerusalem; a highway prepared for our God
Luke 1:13–17, 76–79	Gabriel; Zacharias	John before the Lord in the spirit and power of Elias; "the prophet of the Highest"
John 1:19–28	John to the priests	"I am not"; the voice of Isaiah 40:3
John 3:25–30	John	Sent before him; the friend of the bridegroom; "He must increase"
Matthew 11:2–19; Luke 7:18–35	The Lord	More than a prophet; the messenger of Malachi 3:1; "if ye will receive it, this is Elias"
Matthew 17:1–13; Mark 9:2–13	The Lord	Elias shall first come and restore all things; Elias is come already
Matthew 14:1–2; 16:13–14, with the parallels	Herod; the people	John risen; Elias; a prophet
Matthew 27:46–49; Mark 15:34–36	The bystanders	He calleth Elias; let us see whether Elias will come
Luke 9:51–56	James and John; the Lord	Fire "even as Elias did"; "Ye know not what manner of spirit ye are of"
Acts 3:19–21	Peter	The times of restitution of all things
Revelation 11:3–12	The angel; the narrator	Two witnesses; fire, a shut heaven, the days, the ascent (set beside, not named)

Appendix B. Key Words

The King James Version is the text of the volume. The words below are given in Roman letters for readers who wish to see what stands behind the English. Nothing in the argument depends on a rendering other than the King James rendering.

Words in the passages on Elijah and John.

Word	KJV renders	Where	Note
malak	messenger	Malachi 3:1	The word behind “my messenger”; the name Malachi is its form with “my”
Elias	Elias	Matthew 11:14; 17:11; Luke 1:17; John 1:21	The Greek form of the name Elijah, as the KJV prints it in the New Testament
apokathistemi	restore	Matthew 17:11; Mark 9:12	The verb of the Lord’s “restore all things”
apokatastasis	restitution	Acts 3:21	A noun from the same root as the verb above
herem	curse	Malachi 4:6	The curse with which Malachi 4:6 ends
yom YHWH	day of the LORD	Malachi 4:5	The day before which Elijah is sent

Appendix C. Questions for Study

The questions may be used alone or in a group. Each can be answered from the text, and the chapter that bears on it is given in brackets.

1. What does Malachi 4:4–6 name, in order, and what time mark does it give? [1]
2. What does Elijah say on Carmel about the people's heart, and how does it compare with Malachi 4:6? [2]
3. What is the first scene in Kings that takes Elijah to Horeb, and what does Malachi 4:4 say of Horeb? [2]
4. What does 2 Kings 2:15 say of Elisha, and what is left unsaid? [3]
5. What does the Old Testament report about Elijah's death? [3]
6. How do Malachi 3:1 and Malachi 4:5 differ in who is sent and what follows? [4]
7. Where do the Gospels' quotations of Malachi 3:1 stop? [4]
8. Which text does John use of himself, and which does he not? [5]
9. What does Gabriel say of John in Luke 1:17, and what does he leave out? [6]
10. What are the three denials of John 1:19–25? [7]
11. What does John say in John 3:28–30 of his own place? [7]
12. What does the Lord ask the multitudes, and what is conditional in Matthew 11:14? [8]
13. What does Luke 7:29, 30 report of the people and of the Pharisees and lawyers? [8]
14. Compare Matthew 17:11 and Matthew 17:12. What is the tense of each? [9]
15. What does Mark 9:13 add to Matthew 17:12? [9]
16. In the lists of what the people said, are John and Elias one person or two? [10]
17. What do the bystanders at the cross say? [10]
18. What reasons does chapter 11 give for a further coming? [11]
19. What does the volume say it does not know about that coming? [11]
20. Which objection to the volume's reading is strongest, and how does the volume answer it? [12]

Appendix D. The Key Passages in Full

The passages on which the volume turns are given here in full, so that a reader can test the argument against the whole text and not only against the verses quoted in the chapters. Verse numbers are in bold. A row of dots marks a gap between verses.

D.1 Malachi 1:1; 3:1–5; 4:4–6

1 The burden of the word of the LORD to Israel by Malachi. … **1** Behold, I will send my messenger, and he shall prepare the way before me: and the LORD, whom ye seek, shall suddenly come to his temple, even the messenger of the covenant, whom ye delight in: behold, he shall come, saith the LORD of hosts. **2** But who may abide the day of his coming? and who shall stand when he appeareth? for he is like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' soap: **3** And he shall sit as a refiner and purifier of silver: and he shall purify the sons of Levi, and purge them as gold and silver, that they may offer unto the LORD an offering in righteousness. **4** Then shall the offering of Judah and Jerusalem be pleasant unto the LORD, as in the days of old, and as in former years. **5** And I will come near to you to judgment; and I will be a swift witness against the sorcerers, and against the adulterers, and against false swearers, and against those that oppress the hireling in his wages, the widow, and the fatherless, and that turn aside the stranger from his right, and fear not me, saith the LORD of hosts. … **4** Remember ye the law of Moses my servant, which I commanded unto him in Horeb for all Israel, with the statutes and judgments. **5** Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD: **6** And he shall turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers, lest I come and smite the earth with a curse.

D.2 1 Kings 17:1; 18:36–39; 19:8–18

1 And Elijah the Tishbite, who was of the inhabitants of Gilead, said unto Ahab, As the LORD God of Israel liveth, before whom I stand, there shall not be dew nor rain these years, but according to my word. … **36** And it came to pass at the time of the offering of the evening sacrifice, that Elijah the prophet came near, and said, LORD God of Abraham, Isaac, and of Israel, let it be known this day that thou art God in Israel, and that I am thy servant, and that I have done all these things at thy word. **37** Hear me, O LORD, hear me, that this people may know that thou art the LORD God, and that thou hast turned their heart back again. **38** Then the fire of the LORD fell, and consumed the burnt sacrifice, and the wood, and the stones, and the dust, and licked up the water that was in the trench. **39** And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces: and they said, The LORD, he is the God; the LORD, he is the God. … **8** And he arose, and did eat and drink, and went in the strength of that meat forty days and forty nights unto Horeb the mount of God. **9** And he came thither unto a cave, and lodged there; and, behold, the word of the LORD came to him, and he said unto him, What doest thou here, Elijah? **10** And he said, I have been very jealous for the LORD God of hosts: for the children of Israel have forsaken thy covenant, thrown down thine altars, and slain thy prophets with the sword; and I, even I only, am left; and they seek my life, to take it away. **11** And he said, Go forth, and stand upon the mount before the LORD. And, behold, the LORD passed by, and a great and strong wind rent the mountains, and brake in pieces the rocks before the LORD; but the LORD was not in the wind: and after the wind an earthquake; but the LORD was not in the earthquake: **12** And after

the earthquake a fire; but the LORD was not in the fire: and after the fire a still small voice. **13** And it was so, when Elijah heard it, that he wrapped his face in his mantle, and went out, and stood in the entering in of the cave. And, behold, there came a voice unto him, and said, What doest thou here, Elijah? **14** And he said, I have been very jealous for the LORD God of hosts: because the children of Israel have forsaken thy covenant, thrown down thine altars, and slain thy prophets with the sword; and I, even I only, am left; and they seek my life, to take it away. **15** And the LORD said unto him, Go, return on thy way to the wilderness of Damascus: and when thou comest, anoint Hazael to be king over Syria: **16** And Jehu the son of Nimshi shalt thou anoint to be king over Israel: and Elisha the son of Shaphat of Abel-meholah shalt thou anoint to be prophet in thy room. **17** And it shall come to pass, that him that escapeth the sword of Hazael shall Jehu slay: and him that escapeth from the sword of Jehu shall Elisha slay. **18** Yet I have left me seven thousand in Israel, all the knees which have not bowed unto Baal, and every mouth which hath not kissed him.

D.3 2 Kings 2:1–18

1 And it came to pass, when the LORD would take up Elijah into heaven by a whirlwind, that Elijah went with Elisha from Gilgal. **2** And Elijah said unto Elisha, Tarry here, I pray thee; for the LORD hath sent me to Beth-el. And Elisha said unto him, As the LORD liveth, and as thy soul liveth, I will not leave thee. So they went down to Beth-el. **3** And the sons of the prophets that were at Beth-el came forth to Elisha, and said unto him, Knowest thou that the LORD will take away thy master from thy head to day? And he said, Yea, I know it; hold ye your peace. **4** And Elijah said unto him, Elisha, tarry here, I pray thee; for the LORD hath sent me to Jericho. And he said, As the LORD liveth, and as thy soul liveth, I will not leave thee. So they came to Jericho. **5** And the sons of the prophets that were at Jericho came to Elisha, and said unto him, Knowest thou that the LORD will take away thy master from thy head to day? And he answered, Yea, I know it; hold ye your peace. **6** And Elijah said unto him, Tarry, I pray thee, here; for the LORD hath sent me to Jordan. And he said, As the LORD liveth, and as thy soul liveth, I will not leave thee. And they two went on. **7** And fifty men of the sons of the prophets went, and stood to view afar off: and they two stood by Jordan. **8** And Elijah took his mantle, and wrapped it together, and smote the waters, and they were divided hither and thither, so that they two went over on dry ground. **9** And it came to pass, when they were gone over, that Elijah said unto Elisha, Ask what I shall do for thee, before I be taken away from thee. And Elisha said, I pray thee, let a double portion of thy spirit be upon me. **10** And he said, Thou hast asked a hard thing: nevertheless, if thou see me when I am taken from thee, it shall be so unto thee; but if not, it shall not be so. **11** And it came to pass, as they still went on, and talked, that, behold, there appeared a chariot of fire, and horses of fire, and parted them both asunder; and Elijah went up by a whirlwind into heaven. **12** And Elisha saw it, and he cried, My father, my father, the chariot of Israel, and the horsemen thereof. And he saw him no more: and he took hold of his own clothes, and rent them in two pieces. **13** He took up also the mantle of Elijah that fell from him, and went back, and stood by the bank of Jordan; **14** And he took the mantle of Elijah that fell from him, and smote the waters, and said, Where is the LORD God of Elijah? and when he also had smitten the waters, they parted hither and thither: and Elisha went over. **15** And when the sons of the prophets which were to view at Jericho saw him, they said, The spirit of Elijah doth rest on Elisha. And they came to meet him, and bowed themselves to the ground before him. **16** And they said unto him, Behold now, there be with thy

servants fifty strong men; let them go, we pray thee, and seek thy master: lest peradventure the Spirit of the LORD hath taken him up, and cast him upon some mountain, or into some valley. And he said, Ye shall not send. **17** And when they urged him till he was ashamed, he said, Send. They sent therefore fifty men; and they sought three days, but found him not. **18** And when they came again to him, (for he tarried at Jericho,) he said unto them, Did I not say unto you, Go not?

D.4 Isaiah 40:1–5

1 Comfort ye, comfort ye my people, saith your God. **2** Speak ye comfortably to Jerusalem, and cry unto her, that her warfare is accomplished, that her iniquity is pardoned: for she hath received of the LORD's hand double for all her sins. **3** The voice of him that crieth in the wilderness, Prepare ye the way of the LORD, make straight in the desert a highway for our God. **4** Every valley shall be exalted, and every mountain and hill shall be made low: and the crooked shall be made straight, and the rough places plain: **5** And the glory of the LORD shall be revealed, and all flesh shall see it together: for the mouth of the LORD hath spoken it.

D.5 Luke 1:13–17, 76–79

13 But the angel said unto him, Fear not, Zacharias: for thy prayer is heard; and thy wife Elisabeth shall bear thee a son, and thou shalt call his name John. **14** And thou shalt have joy and gladness; and many shall rejoice at his birth. **15** For he shall be great in the sight of the Lord, and shall drink neither wine nor strong drink; and he shall be filled with the Holy Ghost, even from his mother's womb. **16** And many of the children of Israel shall he turn to the Lord their God. **17** And he shall go before him in the spirit and power of Elias, to turn the hearts of the fathers to the children, and the disobedient to the wisdom of the just; to make ready a people prepared for the Lord. … **76** And thou, child, shalt be called the prophet of the Highest: for thou shalt go before the face of the Lord to prepare his ways; **77** To give knowledge of salvation unto his people by the remission of their sins, **78** Through the tender mercy of our God; whereby the dayspring from on high hath visited us, **79** To give light to them that sit in darkness and in the shadow of death, to guide our feet into the way of peace.

D.6 John 1:19–28; 3:27–30

19 And this is the record of John, when the Jews sent priests and Levites from Jerusalem to ask him, Who art thou? **20** And he confessed, and denied not; but confessed, I am not the Christ. **21** And they asked him, What then? Art thou Elias? And he saith, I am not. Art thou that prophet? And he answered, No. **22** Then said they unto him, Who art thou? that we may give an answer to them that sent us. What sayest thou of thyself? **23** He said, I am the voice of one crying in the wilderness, Make straight the way of the Lord, as said the prophet Esaias. **24** And they which were sent were of the Pharisees. **25** And they asked him, and said unto him, Why baptizest thou then, if thou be not that Christ, nor Elias, neither that prophet? **26** John answered them, saying, I baptize with water: but there standeth one among you, whom ye know not; **27** He it is, who coming after me is preferred before me, whose shoe's latchet I am not worthy to unloose. **28** These things were done in Bethabara beyond Jordan, where John was baptizing. … **27** John answered and said, A man can receive nothing, except it be given him from heaven. **28** Ye yourselves bear me witness, that I said, I am not the Christ, but that I am sent before him. **29** He that hath the bride is the bridegroom: but the friend of the bridegroom, which standeth and

heareth him, rejoiceth greatly because of the bridegroom's voice: this my joy therefore is fulfilled. **30** He must increase, but I must decrease.

D.7 Matthew 11:7–19

7 And as they departed, Jesus began to say unto the multitudes concerning John, What went ye out into the wilderness to see? A reed shaken with the wind? **8** But what went ye out for to see? A man clothed in soft raiment? behold, they that wear soft clothing are in kings' houses. **9** But what went ye out for to see? A prophet? yea, I say unto you, and more than a prophet. **10** For this is he, of whom it is written, Behold, I send my messenger before thy face, which shall prepare thy way before thee. **11** Verily I say unto you, Among them that are born of women there hath not risen a greater than John the Baptist: notwithstanding he that is least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he. **12** And from the days of John the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven suffereth violence, and the violent take it by force. **13** For all the prophets and the law prophesied until John. **14** And if ye will receive it, this is Elias, which was for to come. **15** He that hath ears to hear, let him hear. **16** But whereunto shall I liken this generation? It is like unto children sitting in the markets, and calling unto their fellows, **17** And saying, We have piped unto you, and ye have not danced; we have mourned unto you, and ye have not lamented. **18** For John came neither eating nor drinking, and they say, He hath a devil. **19** The Son of man came eating and drinking, and they say, Behold a man gluttonous, and a winebibber, a friend of publicans and sinners. But wisdom is justified of her children.

D.8 Matthew 17:9–13

9 And as they came down from the mountain, Jesus charged them, saying, Tell the vision to no man, until the Son of man be risen again from the dead. **10** And his disciples asked him, saying, Why then say the scribes that Elias must first come? **11** And Jesus answered and said unto them, Elias truly shall first come, and restore all things. **12** But I say unto you, That Elias is come already, and they knew him not, but have done unto him whatsoever they listed. Likewise shall also the Son of man suffer of them. **13** Then the disciples understood that he spake unto them of John the Baptist.

D.9 Mark 9:11–13

11 And they asked him, saying, Why say the scribes that Elias must first come? **12** And he answered and told them, Elias verily cometh first, and restoreth all things; and how it is written of the Son of man, that he must suffer many things, and be set at nought. **13** But I say unto you, That Elias is indeed come, and they have done unto him whatsoever they listed, as it is written of him.

D.10 Acts 3:19–21

19 Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord; **20** And he shall send Jesus Christ, which before was preached unto you: **21** Whom the heaven must receive until the times of restitution of all things, which God hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets since the world began.

D.11 Revelation 11:3–12

3 And I will give power unto my two witnesses, and they shall prophesy a thousand two hundred and threescore days, clothed in sackcloth. **4** These are the two olive

trees, and the two candlesticks standing before the God of the earth. **5** And if any man will hurt them, fire proceedeth out of their mouth, and devoureth their enemies: and if any man will hurt them, he must in this manner be killed. **6** These have power to shut heaven, that it rain not in the days of their prophecy: and have power over waters to turn them to blood, and to smite the earth with all plagues, as often as they will. **7** And when they shall have finished their testimony, the beast that ascendeth out of the bottomless pit shall make war against them, and shall overcome them, and kill them. **8** And their dead bodies shall lie in the street of the great city, which spiritually is called Sodom and Egypt, where also our Lord was crucified. **9** And they of the people and kindreds and tongues and nations shall see their dead bodies three days and an half, and shall not suffer their dead bodies to be put in graves. **10** And they that dwell upon the earth shall rejoice over them, and make merry, and shall send gifts one to another; because these two prophets tormented them that dwelt on the earth. **11** And after three days and an half the Spirit of life from God entered into them, and they stood upon their feet; and great fear fell upon them which saw them. **12** And they heard a great voice from heaven saying unto them, Come up hither. And they ascended up to heaven in a cloud; and their enemies beheld them.

Appendix E. Where the Passages Are Read

Every passage cited in the chapters, the Preface, the Thesis and the Conclusion, in the order of the Bible, with the pages on which it is read. Each citation is listed as written in the text. The appendices are not indexed. A page number is the number in the footer.

The passages in the order of the Bible.

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
Deuteronomy 28:15	ch. 1, p. 6	
1 Kings 17:1	ch. 2, pp. 7, 10; ch. 11, p. 31	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 17:2	ch. 2, p. 7	
1 Kings 17:3, 4, 9	ch. 2, p. 7	
1 Kings 17:8–24	ch. 2, p. 10	
1 Kings 17:9	ch. 2, p. 7	
1 Kings 17:17	ch. 2, p. 7	
1 Kings 17:20	ch. 2, p. 7	
1 Kings 17:21, 22	ch. 2, p. 7	
1 Kings 17:24	ch. 2, p. 7	
1 Kings 18:1	ch. 2, pp. 7, 10	
1 Kings 18:17, 18	ch. 2, p. 7	
1 Kings 18:19	ch. 2, p. 8	
1 Kings 18:21	ch. 2, p. 8	
1 Kings 18:22	ch. 2, p. 8	
1 Kings 18:30, 31	ch. 2, p. 8	
1 Kings 18:36	ch. 1, pp. 5, 6	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 18:37	ch. 2, p. 8	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 18:38, 39	ch. 2, p. 8	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 19:2–4	ch. 2, p. 8	
1 Kings 19:8	ch. 2, p. 8	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 19:9, 13	ch. 2, p. 8	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 19:10, 14	ch. 9, p. 26	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 19:11, 12	ch. 2, p. 8	In full, Appendix D

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
1 Kings 19:14	ch. 2, p. 8	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 19:15–18	ch. 2, p. 8	In full, Appendix D
1 Kings 19:19	ch. 3, p. 11	
1 Kings 19:19, 21	ch. 2, p. 8	
1 Kings 21:19	ch. 2, p. 9	
1 Kings 21:20	ch. 2, p. 9	
1 Kings 21:27	ch. 2, p. 9	
1 Kings 21:29	ch. 2, p. 9	
2 Kings 1:3	ch. 2, p. 9	
2 Kings 1:8	ch. 2, p. 9; ch. 5, p. 17	
2 Kings 1:10, 12	ch. 2, p. 9	
2 Kings 1:13, 15	ch. 2, p. 9	
2 Kings 2:1	ch. 3, p. 10	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:1, 11	ch. 3, p. 12	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:2, 4, 6	ch. 3, p. 11	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:3, 5	ch. 3, p. 11	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:7, 8	ch. 3, p. 11	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:9	ch. 3, p. 11	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:9, 10	ch. 3, p. 12	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:10	ch. 3, p. 11	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:11	ch. 3, pp. 10, 11	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:12	ch. 3, p. 11	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:13, 14	ch. 3, p. 11	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:15	ch. 3, pp. 11, 12; ch. 6, p. 18; ch. 11, p. 32; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:16	ch. 3, p. 12	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:16–18	ch. 3, p. 12	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:17	ch. 3, p. 12	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 2:18	ch. 3, p. 12	In full, Appendix D
2 Kings 3:11	ch. 3, p. 11	
2 Kings 3:11, 12	ch. 3, p. 13	

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
2 Kings 3:12	ch. 3, p. 11	
2 Chronicles 21:12–15	ch. 3, pp. 12, 13	
Isaiah 35:5, 6	ch. 8, p. 23	
Isaiah 40:1, 2	ch. 5, p. 15	In full, Appendix D
Isaiah 40:1–5	ch. 5, p. 15	In full, Appendix D
Isaiah 40:3	Thesis, p. 3; ch. 5, pp. 15, 16, 17; ch. 7, p. 22; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Isaiah 40:3–5	ch. 12, p. 33	In full, Appendix D
Isaiah 40:4, 5	ch. 5, p. 16	In full, Appendix D
Isaiah 40:6	ch. 5, p. 16	
Isaiah 61:1	ch. 8, p. 23	
Malachi 1:1	Preface, p. 3; ch. 1, pp. 4, 6; ch. 4, p. 13	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 1:2	ch. 1, p. 4	
Malachi 1:6	ch. 1, p. 4	
Malachi 1:6–8	ch. 1, p. 4	
Malachi 2:14–16	ch. 1, p. 4	
Malachi 2:17	ch. 1, p. 4	
Malachi 3:1	Thesis, p. 3; ch. 4, pp. 13, 14, 15; ch. 5, pp. 16, 17; ch. 6, p. 18; ch. 7, p. 21; ch. 8, pp. 22, 23, 24; ch. 12, p. 33; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 3:1–5	ch. 1, p. 4; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 3:2, 3	ch. 4, p. 14	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 3:4	ch. 4, p. 14	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 3:5	ch. 4, p. 14	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 3:8	ch. 1, p. 4	
Malachi 3:13–18	ch. 1, p. 4	
Malachi 3:17	ch. 1, p. 4	
Malachi 4:1	ch. 1, p. 5	
Malachi 4:2	ch. 1, p. 5	
Malachi 4:3	ch. 1, pp. 5, 6	

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
Malachi 4:4	ch. 1, p. 5; ch. 2, pp. 7, 8, 10	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 4:4–6	ch. 1, pp. 4, 6	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 4:5	ch. 1, pp. 5, 6; ch. 2, p. 6; ch. 3, p. 10; ch. 4, p. 15; ch. 5, pp. 16, 17; ch. 7, pp. 20, 21, 22; ch. 11, pp. 30, 32, 33; ch. 12, p. 34; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 4:5, 6	Preface, pp. 2, 3; ch. 4, p. 15; ch. 5, p. 17; ch. 6, p. 18; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Malachi 4:6	ch. 1, p. 6; ch. 2, pp. 7, 8, 10; ch. 6, pp. 17, 18, 19; ch. 11, p. 30	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 3:1, 2	ch. 5, p. 16	
Matthew 3:3	ch. 5, pp. 16, 17	
Matthew 3:4	ch. 5, p. 17	
Matthew 3:5, 6	ch. 5, p. 16; ch. 12, p. 35	
Matthew 11:2, 3	ch. 8, p. 22	
Matthew 11:4	ch. 8, p. 22	
Matthew 11:5	ch. 8, p. 22	
Matthew 11:6	ch. 8, p. 23	
Matthew 11:7–9	ch. 8, p. 23	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 11:9	ch. 8, p. 24	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 11:10	ch. 4, pp. 14, 15; ch. 5, p. 17; ch. 8, pp. 23, 24; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 11:11	ch. 8, pp. 23, 24	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 11:12	ch. 8, p. 23	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 11:13–15	ch. 8, p. 23	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 11:14	Preface, p. 2; ch. 4, p. 15; ch. 5, p. 17; ch. 7, pp. 21, 22; ch. 8, pp. 23, 24, 25; ch. 10, p. 28; ch. 11, pp. 31, 32; ch. 12, pp. 34, 35, 36; Conclusion, pp. 36, 37	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 11:16–19	ch. 8, pp. 23, 24; ch. 11, p. 30; ch. 12, p. 35	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 14:1, 2	ch. 10, p. 27; Conclusion, p. 37	
Matthew 14:1–2	ch. 10, p. 29	
Matthew 14:3–10	ch. 11, p. 30	

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
Matthew 14:10	ch. 10, p. 28; ch. 11, pp. 30, 32	
Matthew 16:13, 14	ch. 10, p. 28; Conclusion, p. 37	
Matthew 16:13–14	ch. 10, p. 29	
Matthew 16:14	Preface, p. 2	
Matthew 17:1, 2	ch. 9, p. 25	
Matthew 17:3	ch. 9, p. 25; ch. 11, pp. 31, 32	
Matthew 17:4	ch. 9, p. 25	
Matthew 17:5	ch. 9, p. 25	
Matthew 17:8	ch. 9, p. 25	
Matthew 17:9	ch. 9, p. 25	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 17:10	Preface, p. 2; ch. 9, p. 25	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 17:10, 11	Preface, p. 3	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 17:11	Preface, p. 2; Thesis, p. 4; ch. 9, pp. 26, 27; ch. 11, pp. 30, 31, 32; ch. 12, pp. 34, 35, 36	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 17:11, 12	Preface, p. 2; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 17:12	Preface, p. 2; ch. 9, pp. 26, 27; ch. 12, p. 34	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 17:13	ch. 9, pp. 26, 27; ch. 12, p. 34	In full, Appendix D
Matthew 27:46, 47	ch. 10, p. 28	
Matthew 27:46–49	ch. 10, p. 29	
Matthew 27:47–49	Conclusion, p. 37	
Matthew 27:49	Preface, p. 2; ch. 10, p. 28	
Mark 1:2	ch. 4, pp. 14, 15; ch. 5, p. 17	
Mark 1:2, 3	ch. 5, p. 16	
Mark 1:3	ch. 5, p. 17	
Mark 1:4	ch. 5, p. 16	
Mark 1:5	ch. 5, p. 16	
Mark 1:6	ch. 2, pp. 9, 10; ch. 5, p. 17	
Mark 6:14, 15	ch. 10, p. 27	
Mark 6:14–16	ch. 10, p. 29	
Mark 6:16	ch. 10, p. 28	

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
Mark 8:27–28	ch. 10, p. 29	
Mark 8:28	ch. 10, p. 28	
Mark 9:4	ch. 9, p. 25	
Mark 9:6	ch. 9, p. 25	
Mark 9:10	ch. 9, p. 25	
Mark 9:11	ch. 9, p. 25	In full, Appendix D
Mark 9:12	ch. 9, p. 26	In full, Appendix D
Mark 9:12, 13	Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Mark 9:13	ch. 9, p. 26; ch. 12, p. 34	In full, Appendix D
Mark 15:34–36	ch. 10, p. 29	
Mark 15:35	ch. 10, p. 28	
Mark 15:36	ch. 10, p. 28	
Luke 1:5	ch. 6, p. 18	
Luke 1:6	ch. 6, p. 18	
Luke 1:10	ch. 6, p. 18	
Luke 1:11	ch. 6, p. 18	
Luke 1:13	ch. 6, p. 18	In full, Appendix D
Luke 1:15	ch. 6, p. 18	In full, Appendix D
Luke 1:16	ch. 2, pp. 8, 10; ch. 6, p. 18	In full, Appendix D
Luke 1:16, 17	ch. 6, p. 19; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Luke 1:17	Preface, p. 2; ch. 3, p. 11; ch. 4, pp. 14, 15; ch. 5, p. 17; ch. 7, p. 21; ch. 11, pp. 31, 32, 33; ch. 12, pp. 34, 35, 36; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Luke 1:67	ch. 6, p. 19	
Luke 1:68–70	ch. 6, p. 19	
Luke 1:71	ch. 6, p. 19	
Luke 1:72, 73	ch. 6, p. 19	
Luke 1:76–78	ch. 6, p. 19	In full, Appendix D
Luke 3:1, 2	ch. 5, p. 16	
Luke 3:4	ch. 5, p. 17	
Luke 3:5, 6	ch. 5, p. 16	

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
Luke 4:25	ch. 2, pp. 7, 10; ch. 11, p. 32	
Luke 4:26	ch. 2, pp. 7, 10	
Luke 7:19, 20	ch. 8, p. 22	
Luke 7:21	ch. 8, p. 22	
Luke 7:26, 27	ch. 8, p. 23	
Luke 7:27	ch. 4, pp. 14, 15; ch. 5, p. 17; ch. 8, p. 24; Conclusion, p. 37	
Luke 7:28	ch. 8, p. 24	
Luke 7:29, 30	ch. 8, p. 24	
Luke 7:30	ch. 12, p. 35	
Luke 7:31–35	ch. 8, p. 24	
Luke 9:7, 8	ch. 10, p. 28	
Luke 9:7–9	ch. 10, p. 29	
Luke 9:18–20	ch. 10, p. 29	
Luke 9:19	ch. 10, p. 28	
Luke 9:20	ch. 10, p. 28	
Luke 9:51–53	ch. 10, p. 29	
Luke 9:51–56	ch. 10, p. 29	
Luke 9:54	ch. 2, pp. 9, 10; ch. 10, p. 29	
Luke 9:55, 56	ch. 10, p. 29	
John 1:19	ch. 7, pp. 20, 21	In full, Appendix D
John 1:19–25	ch. 12, p. 35	In full, Appendix D
John 1:19–28	Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
John 1:20	ch. 7, pp. 20, 21	In full, Appendix D
John 1:21	Preface, p. 2; ch. 5, p. 17; ch. 7, pp. 20, 21, 22; ch. 10, p. 28; ch. 11, pp. 31, 32; ch. 12, pp. 34, 35, 36	In full, Appendix D
John 1:22	ch. 7, p. 20	In full, Appendix D
John 1:23	ch. 5, pp. 16, 17; ch. 7, pp. 20, 22	In full, Appendix D
John 1:24	ch. 7, p. 20; ch. 8, p. 24	In full, Appendix D
John 1:25	ch. 7, p. 20	In full, Appendix D
John 1:26, 27	ch. 7, pp. 20, 22	In full, Appendix D

Passage	Where it is read	Key passage
John 3:26	ch. 7, p. 21	
John 3:27, 28	ch. 7, p. 21	In full, Appendix D
John 3:28	ch. 7, p. 22	In full, Appendix D
John 3:28–30	Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
John 3:29, 30	ch. 7, pp. 21, 22	In full, Appendix D
John 5:33–35	ch. 7, p. 21	
John 6:14	ch. 10, pp. 28, 29	
John 7:40	ch. 10, pp. 28, 29	
Acts 1:6	Preface, p. 3	
Acts 3:12	ch. 11, p. 31	
Acts 3:19–21	ch. 9, p. 26	In full, Appendix D
Acts 3:21	Preface, p. 3; ch. 9, p. 27; ch. 11, pp. 31, 32, 33; ch. 12, pp. 35, 36; Conclusion, p. 37	In full, Appendix D
Acts 3:25	ch. 11, p. 31	
Hebrews 11:5	ch. 3, p. 12	
James 5:17	ch. 2, p. 7; ch. 11, p. 32	
James 5:17, 18	ch. 2, p. 10	
Revelation 11:1, 2	ch. 11, p. 31	
Revelation 11:3	ch. 11, p. 31	In full, Appendix D
Revelation 11:3–12	ch. 11, p. 32	In full, Appendix D
Revelation 11:5	ch. 11, p. 31	In full, Appendix D
Revelation 11:6	ch. 2, pp. 7, 10; ch. 11, p. 31	In full, Appendix D
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